

CM Rekha lays foundation stone for new oxygen park in Burari

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday laid the foundation stone for a new oxygen park in Mukhmelpur village of Burari, announcing a major green development project aimed at improving environmental conditions and public recreational facilities in outer Delhi.

The three-acre park will be developed with modern amenities, walking tracks, landscaped green spaces, and hundreds of trees. The Delhi government has allocated ₹1 crore for the project through the Forest Department, while

another ₹1 crore will be provided from the Chief Minister's MLA discretionary fund.

Addressing residents during the foundation stone ceremony, the Chief Minister said the proposed park would serve not only as a green space but also as a centre for healthier and more active community life. She added that the government plans to develop more oxygen parks across Delhi in the coming years.

The Chief Minister said environmental protection and better quality of life remain key priorities for the government, along with infrastructure development. She stated

that increasing urbanisation and rising population have increased the need for green public spaces where residents can relax, exercise, and reconnect with nature.

According to officials, the oxygen park will include walking and jogging tracks, decorative energy-efficient lighting, seating huts, landscaped lawns, and a pond. Various shade-giving trees and plants will also be planted across the park premises to improve greenery and air quality in the area.

The Chief Minister directed officials to ensure that the project is completed with high standards and equipped



CM Rekha Gupta clicks selfies with people during the foundation stone laying ceremony for the modern Mukhmelpur Park in Burari, New Delhi

with modern facilities so that it becomes one of Delhi's finest parks. She said the park would benefit residents not

only from Mukhmelpur but also from nearby areas, including Jindpur, Bakhtawarpur, Hiranki, and

surrounding villages. Officials said the park is expected to become a public space for exercise, yoga, morning walks, and recreational activities for people of all age groups, including children, women, and senior citizens.

The Chief Minister said the Delhi government and the Municipal Corporation of Delhi are jointly working to create new green spaces and upgrade existing parks throughout the Capital. She added that such projects would help reduce stress, improve public health, and encourage healthier lifestyles among residents.

Highlighting the govern-

ment's environmental initiatives, the Chief Minister said Delhi has set a target of planting more than 70 lakh trees, shrubs, and hedges this year.

She expressed confidence that plantation drives and oxygen parks would contribute significantly towards making Delhi greener and more environmentally sustainable.

According to the Chief Minister, projects worth 720 crore have already been approved for the Burari Assembly constituency following recommendations from local representatives and the area's Member of Parliament. These projects

include sewer lines, drinking water pipelines, and measures aimed at resolving long-standing water supply problems. The Chief Minister further said that projects worth nearly 710,000 crore have been launched in villages and outer Delhi areas, covering sectors such as roads, drainage, transport, education, and healthcare infrastructure.

The Chief Minister said the upgraded facility would create employment opportunities for local youth. North East Delhi MP Manoj Tiwari, MCD Mayor Pravesh Wahi, and several local residents attended the event.

Govindpuri double murder case: Police question husband, probe robbery, personal enmity angles

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

In the murder of a 38-year-old woman and her 14-year-old son inside their residence in Delhi's Govindpuri in the early hours of May 21, the police have questioned multiple suspects, including the woman's husband, as investigators probe robbery and personal enmity angles in the case. However, police have made no arrests in the case so far.

The bodies of Sharda Sahu, a homemaker, and her son Kushal, a Class 7 student, were discovered with stab wounds inside their Govindpuri, Kalkaji residence, police said. Cash and gold jewellery were reported missing from the house.

Police said Vishnu and Sharda had adopted Kushal from their sister-in-law.

A senior police officer told The Pioneer that Delhi Police had questioned around



seven to ten suspects in connection with the murders. The officer also said Vishnu Sahu, Sharda's husband, was being questioned as a suspect as part of the ongoing investigation.

Police sources confirmed that there were no signs of a forced entry into the house where the twin murders took place on Thursday.

There was a lack of functional surveillance cameras in the locality. CCTV cameras installed in the area where

the incident occurred were allegedly non-functional. A senior police official also confirmed to The Pioneer that there were no CCTV cameras in the area where the murder happened, and they were looking at the available footage to trace the attackers.

According to Delhi Police, a PCR call regarding the incident was received at Govindpuri Police Station around 1 am.

Police said Vishnu, a fruit

and vegetable vendor, returned home around 12:30 am and found the front door latched from the outside. On entering the house, he discovered the bodies of his wife and son lying in a pool of blood.

The family consisted of Vishnu, his wife and their son, who occupied the ground floor of the four-storey house they allegedly owned, police sources said.

Senior police officers, including the SHO and ACP, rushed to the spot and secured the crime scene. Crime and forensic science laboratory teams inspected the house, and the bodies were sent for a post-mortem.

The Southeast district police have registered a case under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, including provisions for murder and robbery, and formed multiple teams to trace the culprits.

NCRTC opens commercial space bids at Sarai Kale Khan station

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Capital Region Transport Corporation (NCRTC) has invited bids for commercial spaces at the Sarai Kale Khan Namohar Station on the Delhi to Meerut corridor as part of efforts to improve commuter facilities and develop the station into a major urban transit hub.

NCRTC said around 818 square metres of commercial space on the ground floor of the station will be offered on a licence basis through an e-tendering process. The spaces are spread across eight identified locations and include both bare and built-up units ranging from 17 square metres to 247 square metres.

Officials said the commercial spaces can be used for food outlets, cafés, convenience stores, service centres, pod services and other retail activities aimed at commuters and nearby residents. The licence period for the spaces will range from nine to 15 years.



According to NCRTC, the initiative is intended to provide passengers with better convenience and integrated services within the station premises.

Authorities said the presence of retail and service outlets inside the station would help commuters save time and make travel more comfortable and secure.

The corporation said the station's strategic location and transport connectivity make it suitable for commercial activity. Sarai Kale Khan station is one of the largest stations on the Delhi to Meerut Namohar corridor and is being developed as a major multi-modal transport centre in the national Capital.

The station is connected to Hazrat Nizamuddin Railway Station, Veer Haqiqat Rai Interstate Bus Terminal, the Delhi Metro Pink Line and Ring Road. NCRTC recently operationalised a 280-metre covered foot overbridge equipped with travelators to provide direct access between the Namohar station and Hazrat Nizamuddin Railway Station.

Officials said the new foot overbridge has significantly improved passenger movement and interchange facilities between different transport systems in the area. The station is expected to witness heavy commuter footfall because of its central location and connectivity.

POLICE BUST INTERSTATE NARCOTICS SYNDICATE



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police has busted an interstate narcotics syndicate, arresting nine people and seizing heroin and crude opium worth around ₹16 crore, an official said on Friday. Police said a Rohini team unearthed a drug supply network operating between Manipur and Delhi-NCR while probing a case registered at Budh Vihar police station under the NDPS Act.

According to police, 1,568 grams of heroin and 506 grams of crude opium, capable of producing around 1.5 to 2 kilograms of heroin, were recovered during the operation. A bike and a car allegedly used for transporting narcotics were also seized.

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NOTICE FOR GBM
The General Body Meeting of the Sabha will be held on Sunday the 31st of May 2026 at 10.30 AM at the Sabha's premises at 1640, Khirki Patni Mal, Himmat Garh, Bazar Sita Ram, (Behind National & Grindlays Bank, Asaf Ali Road), Delhi-110006.

Main Agenda of the GB Meeting is the appointment of an Election Officer for the Election of New Office Bearers & Management committee members, besides regular agenda items like Confirmation of the minutes, Status report by the Secretary, Financial update of Sabha's funds etc.

You are requested to attend the meeting.
For Shri Chitra Gupta Sabha
(Sd/-) Anil Kumar Saxena
Hony. General Secretary
9810201984
Date : 14.05.2026

PUBLIC NOTICE
The general public is hereby informed that my client **Sh. Jai Bhagawan Dass Gupta S/o Bhagat Ram R/o D-642, Saraswati Vihar, Pitampura, Delhi 110034** have severed all the relations with his **Grandson namely Ashu Gupta, Grand daughter-in-law Megha Gupta** due to their bad behaviour, and also has disowned and debarred his Grandson, Grand daughter-in-law from all the movable and immovable properties. My client has no connection and relation whatsoever with Ashu Gupta, Megha Gupta. Anybody dealing with Ashu Gupta and Megha Gupta will do so at his/her own risk and responsibility, and my client will not be responsible for any act, deed or dealing done by Ashu Gupta and Megha Gupta.
Sarthak Jain (Advocate) Ch. No. 105, Lawyers Chamber Block III, Delhi High Court, New Delhi-110053



DELHI TRANSCO LIMITED

NOTICE INVITING e – TENDER
Delhi Transco Ltd, a Government of NCT of Delhi Undertaking, invites online tender for the work :
Tender No. T26P750009: Repair and renovation of residential flat situated A-4 Shamnath Marg, DTL.
For complete details of the tender please visit following websites :-
https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in (Tender IDNo. 2026_DTL_291771_1) and **www.dtl.gov.in** with Unique No. DTL-0016-210526
Last date for bid submission:- **16.06.2026 at 01.00 P.M.**
All Corrigendum/Addendum/ Amendments/Date of Extension /Clarifications etc. to this e-tender will be hosted on the above website only. Bidders should regularly visit website to keep themselves updated.

PUBLIC NOTICE
My client Ram Sawanrey, Son of Fagu, Aged about 47 years, and Geeta Devi W/o Ram Sawanrey, Aged about 45 years, R/o House No 182 A Gali No 4, Ekta Vihar, Meethapur Extension, Badarpur Mithe Pur, Dist South Delhi, Delhi-110044 have disowned /debarred their son Sunil, UID 4648-9598-9233 from all relations with him, if anybody deals with him at his/her own risk and consequences in future.
Bittu Kumar (Advocate) Jwicks Justice (Law Firm) Office: C-5/88, 1st Floor, Sec.-6 Rohini, Delhi-85



DELHI BUILDING & OTHER CONSTRUCTION WORKERS WELFARE BOARD
GOVT. OF NCT OF DELHI
'A' WING. 7th FLOOR. VIKAS BHAWAN-II, CIVIL LINES. DELHI - 110054
Email id: bcowhq.delhi@gov.in Phone: 011-23813846. 23813773

NOTICE INVITING e-TENDER

RFP Reference No.: RFP/DBOCW/Kits/2025-26
(Tender ID: 2026_DBCWB_291547_1)

Delhi Building and Other Construction Workers' Welfare Board (DBOCWW Board) invites online Request for Proposal (RFP) from eligible Public Sector Undertakings (PSUs) for "Supply of Summer Kits to Delhi Construction Workers under Labour Welfare Initiative". The project involves procurement, packaging, transportation and distribution of Summer Kits to registered construction workers across Delhi.

The online bid submission process shall commence from 18.05.2026 and the last date for submission of proposals shall be 08.06.2026 up to 05:00 PM through the e-Procurement Portal of the Government of NCT of Delhi.

Interested eligible agencies may download the detailed RFP document from the e-Procurement Portal: <https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in>. The DBOCWW Board reserves the right to accept or reject any or all bids without assigning any reason whatsoever.

Sd/- Secretary
Delhi Building and Other Construction Workers Welfare Board
DIP/Shabdarth/Classified/0067/26-27



कार्यालय, नगर पालिक निगम, कोरबा (छत्तीसगढ़)
ई-प्रोक्यूरमेंट निविदा सूचना
क. 15/निर्माण/2026 दिनांक 20.05.2026
एकीकृत पंजीयन प्रणाली अंतर्गत सक्षम श्रेणी में पंजीकृत टेकेदारों से निम्नलिखित निर्माण कार्य हेतु (**Online**)आनलाईन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है।

क्र.	कार्य का विवरण	अनुमानित लागत (₹. लाख में)	निविदा डालने की अंतिम तिथि
1	नगर पालिक निगम क्षेत्रांतर्गत कोरबा ज़ोन में नाली, सड़क, भवन एवं विद्युतीकरण कार्य का परम्पत एवं संधारण कार्य हेतु वार्षिक दर निर्धारण (परम्पत एवं संधारण मद) (द्वितीय निविदा)	100.00	04.06.2026 (T.No. 191339)

उपरोक्त कार्यों की निविदा की जानकारी ई-प्रोक्यूरमेंट वेब पोर्टल <http://eproc.cgstate.gov.in> से डाउनलोड की जा सकती है, साथ ही निगम के वेब साईट www.korbamunicipal.in पर भी देखी जा सकती है।

।। स्वच्छ भारत निर्माण में योगदान दें ।।

अधीक्षक अभियंता
नगर पालिक निगम
कोरबा (छत्तीसगढ़)

PUBLIC NOTICE
NOTICE is hereby given that Mr. Narendra Singh & Smt Vineeta Sirohi (hereinafter referred to as the said Mortgagees/Borrowers), are purchasing Flat No. 07, Type II, Block D-7, First Floor, Rail Vihar, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad (adm. 690 Sq. Ft.) (hereinafter referred to as the said property) from Mr. Sunil Kumar Bahl, who became the owner of the said property vide Conveyance Deed dated 18.01.2012 (regd. as Doc. No. 1723) read with Will dated 24.01.2012 (regd. as Doc. No. 71). The Borrower will create mortgage in respect of the said property in favour of our clients Axis Bank Ltd., Axis House, Sector 128, Noida.
Any person, body, individual, institution having any claim and/or objection in respect of the said property by way of sale, exchange, lease, lien, mortgage, charge, encumbrance, gift, trust, easement, maintenance, inheritance, testamentary deposition or otherwise or having in their custody any title documents pertaining to the said property shall communicate the same to the undersigned at our address within 07 days from the publication of this notice with documentary evidence in support thereof, failing which all the claim, of such person shall be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned. Any objections raised after the completion of the 07 days shall not be binding upon the said property or my client.
Adv. Simran Bajaj
100, 1st Floor, Okhla Phase-III, New Delhi-110020
Phone: +91 1149774545/99

ASSOCIATED FINMAN LIMITED				
Regd. Office: 59/17, Ground Floor, Bahubali Apartments, New Rohtak Road, New Delhi-110005				
CIN: L65910DL1984PLC018871				
Email Id: associatedfinman1984@gmail.com Tel No. : +91 1132963621 Website: www.associates.net.in				
Statement of Audited Standalone Financial Results for the Quarter and year ended 31st March 2026				
(Rs. In Lacs)				
Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter ended 31.03.2026	Quarter ended 31.03.2025	Year ended 31.03.2026
1.	Revenue from Operations	10.75	-	37.75
2.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	25.78	9.52	54.11
3.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	25.78	9.52	54.11
4.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	18.57	7.15	39.77
5.	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	18.57	7.15	39.77
6.	Equity Share Capital (Face Value Rs. 10- each)	90.53	90.53	90.53
7.	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the previous year	-	-	973.52
8.	Earnings Per Share (of Rs. 10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) - 1. Basic: 2. Diluted:	2.05	0.79	4.39
Notes: 1. The above is an extract of the detailed format of quarterly/annual financial results filed with the stock exchange under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the quarterly & year to date financial results are available on the Stock Exchange website (www.mseil.in). 2. The above results were reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at its meeting held on Thursday, 21st May 2026.				
For and on behalf of Associated Finman Limited Sd/- Naveen Kumar Thakur Director DIN: 09694776				
Date: 21.05.2026 Place: Delhi				

CM Rekha rationalises water, sewer infrastructure charges

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday announced a major relief measure for residents, housing units, institutions and industries by rationalising water and sewer Infrastructure Charges (IFC). Now, water and infrastructure charges will be determined based on actual water demand rather than the total area of a building.

Addressing a press conference, CM Rekha Gupta said properties located in E and F category colonies will receive a 50 per cent concession in IFC, while those in G and H category colonies will be eligible for concessions of up to 70 per cent.

“IFC will be levied only on properties/units built on plot size of more than 200 sqm. 6. Plot size of more than 200 sqm will be determined on the basis of property documents such as Conveyance Deed, Sale Deed, Registered GPA, Agreement to Sell, etc. Dwelling units (residential category) of size 50 sqm or less, constructed on plots of

more than 200 sqm, will be given an additional rebate of 50 per cent on net IFC payable for water and sewer,” she said. The decision aims to reduce the unnecessary financial burden on citizens, enhance transparency and encourage development, Rekha Gupta said while giving details of the new measure during a news conference.

The Chief Minister said that the IFC will apply only to new construction projects or additional construction carried out on an existing property. Redevelopment projects where water demand does not increase will not attract IFC. In addition, non-FAR areas as well as open and uncovered spaces will not be included in water demand calculations or in the assessment of IFC.

She said the Delhi Government’s objective is to provide relief to citizens, strengthen basic infrastructure and establish Delhi as a model in the fields of water management, sewage treatment and environmental protection.



Rekha Gupta said the Government has decided to provide special relief to different categories of colonies and economically affected sections. Religious institutions and charitable organisations registered under Section 12AB will also be entitled to an additional 50 per cent concession on water and sewer IFC charges.

To promote environmental protection, institutions and commercial establishments adopting a Zero Liquid Discharge (ZLD) system will

receive up to a 50 per cent concession in sewer IFC.

The Chief Minister clarified that this benefit will be available only to institutions and commercial establishments where ZLD-based Sewage Treatment Plants (STPs) have been installed and are fully operational in accordance with the standards prescribed by the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) and the Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC).

She warned that if inspections find an STP to be non-

functional or not operating as required, the concession will be withdrawn. In such cases, a penalty at the rate of 0.05 per cent per day will also be imposed on the concession amount granted earlier.

Families building new homes or carrying out additional construction often had to pay charges running into several lakh rupees, causing significant hardship.

She said that once implemented, the revised policy would make it easier to build homes and undertake devel-

opment projects in Delhi while providing citizens with direct financial relief worth several lakh rupees.

On the occasion, Delhi Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said that for years the previous Aam Aadmi Party government had turned the IFC system into an instrument of harassment rather than a means of relief for Delhi residents.

Charges that were once reasonable and practical were shifted from a usage-based model to a complex area-based calculation system, resulting in fee increases of six to seven times. Ordinary families attempting to build homes were often handed demands of ₹15-20 lakh or even more.

Citizens found themselves trapped in complicated rules relating to built-up area, FAR, balconies, staircases and various other parameters. This, he said, led to corruption, harassment and countless visits to government offices. Instead of helping citizens, the entire system had been

structured in a way that pushed them into unnecessary difficulties.

The Water Minister said the present Government has now completely overhauled the system and made the IFC process simple, transparent and fair.

Plots measuring up to 200 square metres will continue to remain exempt from charges, and there will be no scope for unnecessary measurements or harassment by officials. Whatever is recorded in the official documents

will be accepted as final. He added that in many cases where people were previously compelled to pay as much as ₹15-16 lakh under the old system, the amount has now been reduced to around ₹2-3 lakh.

Calling it a major relief for Delhi’s middle class, homeowners and ordinary families, Singh said the government’s commitment is clear, honest governance, less corruption, fewer complexities and maximum relief for the people of Delhi.



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DU women’s hostel protest: Administration grants stay extension till June 30



ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Women students at the University Hostel for Women at Delhi University staged a late-night sit-in protest that stretched past midnight and into the early hours of Friday.

The students refused to leave until the hostel administration put its assurances in writing. At 3.30 am, they got what they came for: a written notice extending residency for final-year students till June 30, 2026, and a commitment to address basic amenities that had been failing for months.

The protest began at around 9:30 pm on Thursday, with residents gathering outside the hostel premises and raising slogans against the administration. It continued for over six hours. The immediate trigger was a hostel administration order demanding Rs 450 per day from students who continued to stay beyond seven days after their examinations ended, despite many students having already paid hostel fees in advance for June and July. “We refused to leave until we

received the written order. Around 3:30 am, we finally had the written assurance,” a student said on the condition of anonymity.

The official notice, signed by the resident tutor and warden, confirmed that final-year students would be permitted to stay as regular residents until June 30, 2026.

It also stated that issues raised by residents, including adding chairs to the reading room and arranging coolers in the mess, were under serious consideration and would be addressed without delay. By Friday morning, additional chairs had been placed in the reading room, and two working coolers had been installed in the mess as a stopgap until the air conditioners were repaired.

The grievances behind the protest had been building for months. PhD student Anshika Kumari, from Delhi University’s Hindi department, said students had been dealing with irregular water supply, poor-quality drinking water, and insufficient seating in the reading room for a long time. “It is peak summer, and the mess air conditioners are still not functioning,” she said.

Government ties up with IIT Kanpur to fight air pollution

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Friday signed a five-year agreement with the AIRAWAT Research Foundation of IIT Kanpur to strengthen air pollution control in the Capital through artificial intelligence, advanced monitoring systems, and predictive technology.

The Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) was signed between the Delhi Environment Department and the IIT Kanpur Foundation in the presence of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa.

Under the agreement, Delhi will develop an advanced air quality management system based on artificial intelligence, hyper-local pollution monitoring, satellite data, and scientific forecasting tools.

Officials said the initiative is aimed at improving pollu-



tion tracking, identifying local pollution sources more accurately, and enabling faster government response.

One of the key features of the project will be the development of an AI-based Decision Support System capable of forecasting pollution levels up to 48 to 72 hours in advance.

The system will also help identify pollution hotspots across the city through real-time monitoring and predictive analytics.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the partnership would help the government adopt a more scientific and technology-driven approach to tackle Delhi’s long-standing air pollution problem.



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VGRC to be held in Vadodara in June

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

The Vibrant Gujarat Regional Conference (VGRC) focusing on the central part of the state is scheduled to be held in Vadodara during the last week of June, officials said on Friday.

The region encompasses Ahmedabad, Gandhinagar, Vadodara, Anand, Kheda, Panchmahal, Dahod, Chhotaudepur, Narmada, and Mahisagar districts, accounting for 28 per cent of Gujarat's total manufacturing output, an official release said.

As per district-level data from Annual Survey of Industries 2022-23, central Gujarat contributed 93 per cent of the state's total other transport equipment manufacturing output (which includes railway locomotives, rolling stock, air and space-craft, two and three-wheeled vehicles), 92 per cent of auto and auto components, 70 per cent of beverages, and 63 per cent each of pharmaceuticals and electrical equipment. Around 62 per cent of the total area within Gujarat



is covered under the influence area of Delhi-Mumbai Industrial Corridor (DMIC), making the state an ideal destination for investors, the release added. There are two flagship projects of central Gujarat region in various phases of development, namely the 5,560 acre Dholera Special Investment Region (DSIR) and the 2,849 acre Mandal-Becharaji Special Investment Region (MBSIR).

"Vadodara's chemicals and petrochemicals sector accounted for 61 per cent of the district's total manufacturing output. Ahmedabad leads in auto and auto Components (18 pc), textiles (15 pc), basic metals (13 pc), and pharmaceuticals (9 pc). Gandhinagar's manufacturing output is driven by food processing (18 pc), basic metals (17 pc).

India's power demand hits all-time high amid heat wave

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An unrelenting heat wave sweeping across vast swathes of India has soared electricity demand, and the Ministry of Power on Friday urged consumers to use power wisely and judiciously.

The appeal came at a time when 97 cities of the world's 100 hottest cities recorded 45 degree plus temperature, with some clocking 48 degrees. The Government assured that it is equipped to meet the surging power demand. The biggest concern for residents is that there appears to be no immediate relief from the searing heat, with the Nautapa, a nine-day scorching heat beginning



A woman covering herself due to heatwave in New Delhi

PTI

from May 25. India's daytime peak power demand touched an all-time high of 270.82 gigawatts (GW) on May 21, with the Ministry of Power saying electricity consumption has broken previous records for four

consecutive days due to intense summer conditions. In a post on X, the Ministry said rising temperatures and prolonged heatwave conditions have led to a sharp increase in electricity consumption, particular-

ly during daytime hours when cooling demand remains at its peak. "Due to the intense heat wave in the country, the electricity demand is also increasing," the ministry said.

According to AQL.in, 97 of the world's 100 hottest cities on Friday afternoon were in India, as a brutal heatwave tightened its grip across northern, central and eastern parts of the country, pushing temperatures well above 45 degrees Celsius by noon. Datta showed the global top-100 hottest cities list at 2:50 pm IST were overwhelmingly dominated by Indian cities, with Balangir in Odisha emerging as the hottest location at 48°C. It was followed by Sasaram in Bihar at 48°C and Varanasi at 47°C.

DU staff oppose move to rename Dyal Singh Evening College

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Teachers and staff members of Delhi University's (DU) Dyal Singh Evening College on Friday met the chairman of the college Governing Body in a renewed effort to stop the proposed renaming of the institution.

The move comes ahead of a Governing Body meeting scheduled for Saturday, where members are expected to approve and release the minutes of a December 2025 meeting in which the proposal for changing the college's name was passed. The university administra-



tion had announced in December last year that Dyal Singh Evening College would be renamed after Sikh warrior Banda Singh Bahadur. The college is currently named after Sardar Dyal Singh Majithia, a noted

19th-century philanthropist, educationist and social reformer. The proposed renaming has triggered repeated protests by the college staff association, which has demanded that the decision be withdrawn.

Mithilesh Kumar Singh, president of the staff association, said the delegation met the Governing Body chairman to press for reconsideration of the proposal before Saturday's meeting.

According to Singh, the proposal to change the name of the college was approved during the Governing Body meeting held on December 5, 2025, and later forwarded to Delhi University authorities.

He said the association wants the matter to be discussed in detail within the college before any further steps are taken. "We have requested that the principal

convene a proper meeting of the staff council to discuss the issue," Singh said.

The controversy has continued for several months, with members of the teaching staff arguing that the decision should involve wider consultation within the institution.

In April, the staff council had staged a protest over the issue and demanded formal discussion on the proposal. Following the protest, the college principal wrote to Delhi University Vice-Chancellor Yogesh Singh seeking directions regarding the convening of a staff council meeting.

Ladakh DGP Mukesh Singh transferred to Manipur as New Police Chief

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre has approved the inter-cadre deputation of Ladakh DGP Mukesh Singh to the Manipur cadre for three years, paving the way for him to become the state's next Director General of Police.

The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet



(ACC) cleared the move for the 1996-batch AGMUT cadre IPS officer in relaxation of standard conditions and in public interest. The deci-

sion came just a day after incumbent Manipur DGP Rajiv Singh was elevated to Secretary (Security) in the Cabinet Secretariat.

A 1996-batch officer with a BTech from IIT Delhi, Mukesh Singh brings extensive experience in counter-insurgency and internal security. He has served as SSP in militancy-affected districts of Jammu and

Kashmir, as IG Jammu, ADG ITBP, and in senior roles with the National Investigation Agency.

His proven ability in handling complex security issues in sensitive border regions is expected to strengthen policing in Manipur. Rajiv Singh, a 1993-batch Tripura cadre IPS officer, took charge as Manipur DGP in June 2023, weeks after ethnic violence

erupted on May 3, 2023, between the Meitei and Kuki-Zo communities.

He managed operations during the most turbulent period. Nonetheless, the state continues to face deep ethnic fault lines, buffer zones, sporadic clashes, and abductions even after President's Rule ended in February 2026 and a new Government took office.

Govt announces Smart Border push for...

One of the foundational pillars of the smart border is an extensive network of high-resolution smart cameras and electro-optic systems. These include day-and-night CCTV, thermal-imaging cameras capable of detecting human body heat even in complete darkness, fog, or thick foliage, and infrared night-vision devices. Many of these cameras are equipped with artificial intelligence that can automatically distinguish among humans, animals, vehicles, and drones and instantly flag suspicious activity.

Complementing the cameras are advanced ground surveillance radars and battlefield radars that can detect movement several kilometres away, including low-flying drones used for smuggling or reconnaissance. These systems work alongside perimeter intrusion detection systems, fibre-optic sensors buried along fences, seismic sensors that detect footsteps or vehicle vibrations, laser beams, and underground monitors designed to detect tunnelling attempts. Together they form a virtual, invisible fence that triggers alerts the moment any breach is attempted.blighter.com

Uncrewed Aerial Vehicles (UAVs), both fixed-wing and rotary drones, will play a crucial role in covering difficult terrain. Equipped with high-definition and thermal cameras, these drones will provide real-time video feeds to command centres, conduct autonomous patrols and offer rapid aerial verification whenever ground sensors detect activity. BSF units have already been training with drone fleets, and their deployment is expected to scale up significantly under the newproject.carnegieendowment.org

All these devices will feed data into centralised Command and Control Centres through high-speed fibre-optic and satellite communication networks. Artificial intelligence and machine learning algorithms will analyse the massive influx of information in real time, filter out false alarms, predict infiltration patterns and generate instant alerts to the nearest BSF posts and quick-reaction teams. This "multi-sensor fusion" approach ensures that information from cameras, radars, drones and ground sensors is combined into a single, comprehensive operational picture.

Once fully implemented, the smart border is expected to deliver near-instant detection and response capabilities, significantly reducing dependence on round-the-clock physical patrolling while enhancing effectiveness in challenging weather and terrain. Officials say the system will also help counter emerging threats such as drone-based smuggling and coordinated infiltration attempts.

The project aligns with the government's broader objective of creating a technology-augmented security architecture along both the

western and eastern frontiers. With State Governments in Assam, West Bengal and Tripura already on board, the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) is expected to hold coordination meetings soon to ensure seamless centre-state collaboration. As India moves towards making its borders truly 'smart', the initiative is being watched closely as a potential model for modern border management, blending physical infrastructure with cutting-edge technology to safeguard national security and territorial integrity.

Rajya Sabha elections for 26 seats on June 18: EC

While the NDA is set to bag Pawar's seat, going by its strength in the State Assembly, the TVK is likely to get the lone Rajya Sabha seat from Tamil Nadu, going for a bypoll. The tenure of Pawar's seat will be till July 4, 2028, while that for the Tamil Nadu seat will be till June 29, 2028.

In Andhra Pradesh, the TDP will win all four States for the Council of States. Similarly, in Gujarat, the BJP is likely to win all four seats, grabbing the seat vacated by Congress Shaktisinh Gohil. At present, the BJP has three MPs - RH Mokariya, Narhari Amin and Ramila Becharbhai Bara. In Jharkhand, the JMM-Congress alliance is likely to win both the seats, but the BJP, which has 21 seats of its own, may try to bag one seat with the help of cross-voting by four Opposition members.

If MLAs vote according to party lines, the NDA is likely to increase its tally from 15 to 17, while the Opposition's tally may rise from five to seven. YSR Congress is likely to lose all three of its seats. This election could also see the Congress losing its representation from Gujarat, where the BJP decimated it in the last polls.

In Karnataka, the BJP has two members (Narayana Koragappa and Iranna Kadadi) and its ally JD(S), one, while the Congress has one. The Congress is likely to gain one seat in this election owing to its numerical advantage in the Assembly, and with Kharge's re-nomination being a foregone conclusion, all eyes are on who would be the second candidate. Gowda is also likely to get a renomination with BJP support.

In Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan, the Congress will get one seat each, while the BJP will win two seats in each of the States, going by their current numbers. In Karnataka, the Congress will win three seats, and the BJP will get only one seat.

Among those who are retiring from the Rajya Sabha are Gowda, Congress president Kharge (both from Karnataka), Union ministers Ravneet Singh (Rajasthan) and George Kurian (Madhya Pradesh), former chief minister Digvijay Singh, and Congress leader Shaktisinh Gohil.

Besides Ravneet Singh, the members whose tenure is ending in Rajasthan are Neeraj Dangi of the Congress and Rajendra Gehlot of the BJP.



Pawan Khara

he has been giving that to people for the last 12 years.

He said earlier, Modi said he wanted 60 days and then changed the goalpost to 60 weeks and then 60 years, but never fulfilled the promises of giving a home to every household by 2022 or doubling farmers' income by 2022.

He added that Modi has coined the slogan of 'Viksit Bharat 2047' even when he is unable to provide petrol to people for going to office, and is asking them to work from home instead.

Two arrested for assaulting tourists in Rishikesh



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Dehradun

The Rishikesh Police have arrested two men for allegedly assaulting tourists over a misunderstanding in the Kale Ki Dhal area of Rishikesh.

According to the police, the action was taken based on a complaint lodged on May 20 by Satveer, a resident of Haryana's Kaithal. Satveer told the police that he arrived in Rishikesh with his friends in a car. A misunderstanding with a local woman occurred in the Kale Ki Dhal area.

Following an argument, a crowd gathered, which allegedly assaulted Satveer and his friends. The victims sustained injuries during the attack, and their vehicle was also damaged, according to the police.

whether there was any attempt to interfere with or alter surveillance records following the event. They have demanded an independent technical audit of all CCTV systems connected to the house.

Investigators plan to closely examine the cameras' functionality, maintenance history, and handling as part of the broader probe.

Giribala Singh has denied attempting to influence the investigation. She claims she made the calls in response to people who contacted her to offer condolences following the tragedy. She also denied interfering with the evidence and questioned the manner in which the investigation against her was being conducted. Meanwhile, police have reportedly issued repeated notices asking her to formally cooperate with investigators and record her statement in the case. Twisha Sharma's family says the case goes beyond a single death, calling it a test of public trust in the justice system. They argue that only an independent agency like the CBI can ensure a fair, transparent, and unbiased investigation.

The family also criticises efforts to divert attention to Twisha Sharma's personal life, urging that investigators keep the focus on establishing accountability and uncovering the truth behind her death. With the State Government now recommending a CBI inquiry, the case is expected to enter a more intensive phase. Scrutiny is likely to expand to digital evidence, surveillance records, and the conduct of all those involved in the aftermath of the incident.

Gurugram admin to penalise staff...

All Government employees are reminded of the provisions under the Haryana Civil Services (Government Employees' Conduct) Rules, 2016," said the DC Advisory of May 22, 2026.

While reminding the workforce of the mandates which call for absolute integrity, devotion to duty, and conduct befitting a Government employee, it mentions that such acts are prejudicial to departmental discipline as misconduct. "Canvassing is prohibited by employees from using political or external influence to further service-related interests, including transfers/postings," the advisory said.

Employees have been strictly directed not to use recommendations or unofficial channels for transfer/posting matters and allowed submission of grievances or representations only through the proper official channel.

"Any employee found violating these instructions shall be liable for disciplinary action under the Haryana Civil Services (Punishment & Appeal) Rules, 2016 and other applicable rules/instructions. All concerned officers have been instructed to ensure strict compliance and circulate this advisory among employees," said the advisory.

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Rajasthan has a total of 10 Rajya Sabha seats. The BJP and the Congress currently have five members each. Given the present strength of parties in the 200-member Rajasthan Assembly, the BJP is expected to win two of the three seats, while the Congress is likely to secure one. The BJP has 118 MLAs in the Assembly, while the Congress has 67 members. The BSP has two MLAs, the Bharat Adivasi Party has four, the Rashtriya Lok Dal has one, and Independents have eight.

One each seat in Manipur, Arunachal Pradesh, Meghalaya and Mizoram are also going to polls on June 18. The BJP is likely to retain the seats of Maharaja Sanajaoba Leishemba in Manipur and Nabam Rebia's in Arunachal Pradesh. The NPP is likely to retain Wanweiroi Kharlukhi's seat in Meghalaya, while in Mizoram, the MNF (K Vanlalvena) may lose its seat to the ruling ZPM.

NIA chargesheet maps deadly Pahalgam attack

On April 21, 2025, the terrorists sought refuge with local pony operators near Baisaran. They arrived in the evening and spoke Urdu with a Punjabi accent. Their bags were hidden. The Jothar duo provided them with food, water, and packed rotis. The attackers asked about security arrangements and the upcoming Amarnath Yatra before leaving around 10 pm. The NIA says the locals were paid for their assistance and had previously hosted the terrorists.

On the day of the attack, the terrorists were seen in the Baisaran Valley area. According to the chargesheet, they sat under a tree and ate lunch shortly before launching the assault. Then, they retrieved blankets from their bags. Draping the blankets over themselves for camouflage, they moved into position near a rivulet to observe tourist activity.

One terrorist wore a helmet-mounted GoPro-style action camera to record the killings. The trio crossed into the meadow and strategically positioned themselves. Two stood near the entry gate by the toilets and dhabas. The third took a position toward the zipline area. They created an 'enclosed kill zone' in the central open meadow. The area is accessible only on foot or by pony and is surrounded by dense pine forests.

The assault began at 2:23 pm. At that precise time, the terrorists opened fire. One started with an M-4 carbine, and the others used AK-47 rifles. They deliberately targeted non-Muslims. Attackers asked victims to recite the Kalma (Islamic declaration of faith). Those who could not were shot. In some cases, Hindu men were forced to remove their trousers to check for circumcision. A local pony operator was killed trying to disarm one attacker. Several victims were executed at close range while hiding behind trees. After the massacre, the terrorists fired celebratory shots as they escaped into the pine forests. They exploited the lack of armed security in the area.

The NIA chargesheet highlights strong evidence of cross-border involvement. Investigators found Pakistani-origin mobile phones. IMEIs were traced to Lahore and Karachi. They also found body cameras, Pakistani voter IDs, and food items like chocolates manufactured in Pakistan. The agency traced communications and instructions to the handler Sajid Jatt, who was operating from Pakistan. Security forces neutralised the three terrorists on July 28, 2025, during Operation Mahadev in the Dachigam forests.

TRF initially claimed responsibility but later retracted the statement. The NIA described the attack as part of Pakistan's ongoing proxy war strategy. Prosecutors have filed the chargesheet in a special NIA court in Jammu, and the case no stands at the trial stage.

Investigators say timely information from the local facilitators could have prevented the tragedy. The massacre devastated families and severely hit Kashmir's tourism. The NIA chargesheet provides the most comprehensive official account so far of how the Pahalgam horror unfolded that afternoon.

Security forces killed the terrorists in July 2025, and authorities confirmed their identities using biometric and other evidence. In December 2025, the NIA filed a chargesheet in a special court in Jammu, describing a wider pattern of Pakistan-backed proxy war.

Twisha Sharma case: MP Govt proposes CBI probe

The controversy intensified after Twisha Sharma's family sought an independent inquiry into a series of phone calls allegedly made by Giribala Singh shortly after the incident. According to the family, calls were placed to judges, senior officials, Lokayukta members, and CCTV technicians right after Twisha's death.

The family questioned why multiple influential individuals and technical personnel contacted authorities so quickly, while they struggled to get clear information about their daughter's condition. In a strongly worded statement, the family demanded a forensic examination of all call records and digital communication linked to the case. They maintained that every interaction after the death should be investigated. This would help determine whether there was any attempt to influence the investigation or manipulate evidence.

The issue of surveillance footage has also become a major concern in the investigation. Giribala Singh reportedly told a magistrate that the eight CCTV cameras installed at the residence were displaying incorrect timestamps, with discrepancies ranging from two days to more than two hours before or after the actual time.

Twisha Sharma's family has expressed suspicion over the timing of the disclosure, which occurred after the incident. They questioned

217 Indians joined Russian forces, 49 killed: Centre to SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre on Friday told the Supreme Court that 217 Indian nationals had reportedly joined the Russian armed forces amid the ongoing Russia-Ukraine war, and 49 have lost their lives in the conflict.

In a status report filed before the top court, the Centre said that pursuant to sustained diplomatic engagement undertaken by the Government of India with the Russian Federation, 139 Indian nationals have already been released from the contracts they signed to join the Russian Army.

“Further, 49 Indian nationals are reported to have lost their lives in the conflict. Additionally, 6 Indian nationals have been confirmed missing by the Russian side, whereas the status of 23 individuals remains unknown



and continues to be under active follow-up by the Embassy of India in Moscow with the Russian authorities,” the report said.

The status report was filed in a plea before the top court seeking directions to the Centre to take steps to facilitate the safe repatriation of 26 Indian citizens who have allegedly been detained in Russia and forced to fight in the ongoing war with

Ukraine. “It is submitted that as per the latest information available with the Ministry of External Affairs, approximately 217 Indian nationals had reportedly joined the Russian armed forces,” the status report said.

On Friday, the plea came up for hearing before a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joyimalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi.

Additional Solicitor General

Aishwarya Bhati, appearing for the Centre, referred to the status report.

The report said that in order to facilitate the tracing of missing individuals and identification of mortal remains, DNA reports of the immediate family members of 21 individuals have been collected and transmitted to the Russian authorities with active facilitation by the Government of India.

It said all such cases were being dealt with on utmost priority and were under continuous follow-up with the Russian authorities for resolution, while simultaneously keeping the affected family informed about the developments.

The report said that with respect to the 26 individuals referred to in the plea, as per the present status available with the authorities, 14 cases pertained to reported deaths.

Congress MP writes to ministers over soaring India-UAE airfares

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Congress leader and Member of Parliament has written to the Union Finance Minister and the External Affairs Minister, urging immediate Government intervention to address the sharp rise in airfares on India-UAE and other Gulf routes, which has placed severe financial strain on millions of Indian expatriate workers and their families.

In the letter titled “Appeal to the Hon’ble Ministers regarding rising Air Fares on India-UAE & Gulf Routes and need for Immediate Corrective Action,” the MP highlighted the growing hardships faced by over one crore Indians living and working across the Gulf region.

The letter noted that the majority of expatriate



Indians in the Gulf are middle-class workers whose earnings support millions of families in India. For many, the annual summer visit home is “not a luxury but a necessity,” providing the only opportunity during the year to reunite with their loved ones.

According to the MP, employers in the UAE and Gulf region generally provide a Fixed Travel Allowance (FTA) of around AED 1,000 per person, which, until recently, helped

Nation Focus



President Droupadi Murmu with Chief of Defence Staff General Anil Chauhan and his spouse during a meeting in New Delhi

OUTGOING CDS GENERAL ANIL CHAUHAN MEETS PRESIDENT

Outgoing Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) General Anil Chauhan called on President Droupadi Murmu at the Rashtrapati Bhavan on Friday. The President’s office shared a picture of the meeting through a post on social media. “Chief of Defence Staff, General Anil Chauhan, along with his spouse, called on President Droupadi Murmu at Rashtrapati Bhavan,” it said. General Chauhan completes his tenure on May 30. The Centre has appointed Lieutenant General (retired) NS Raja Subramani as the new CDS.



UNION GOVT LAUNCHES JEEVAN APP, SHATAYU DASHBOARD

Union Minister for Social Justice and Empowerment Virendra Kumar on Friday launched the “JEEVAN” mobile application and the “SHATAYU” dashboard aimed at strengthening support services and caregiving systems for senior citizens across the country. The “JEEVAN” (Joint Elderly Empowerment and Virtual Assistance Network) app has been developed to improve the safety, welfare, healthcare access and social inclusion of elderly citizens through a digital platform. According to the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment, the app provides information on Government schemes and welfare programmes, emergency assistance and support services.

India’s UPI to go live in Cyprus from 2027, boosting digital and economic ties

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

In a major step toward expanding India’s global digital payments network, India’s Unified Payments Interface (UPI) will become operational in Cyprus from next year, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) announced on Friday.

The development comes during the four-day State Visit of Cypriot President Nikos Christodoulides to India from May 20 to May 23, 2026, at the invitation of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Addressing a special media briefing on the visit, MEA Secretary (West) Sibi George described the

move as a significant milestone in strengthening bilateral cooperation and financial connectivity between the two nations.

“UPI will become operational in Cyprus from next year, which is a significant step forward,” George said. The launch of India’s flagship digital payment platform in Cyprus is expected to enhance cross-border financial transactions, promote fintech collaboration, and support growing business and tourism exchanges between the two countries.

The MEA also highlighted the expanding economic relationship between India and Cyprus. Cyprus



is currently the ninth-largest source of foreign direct investment (FDI) into India and ranks second within the European Union after the

Netherlands, with cumulative investments of nearly \$16 billion since 2000.

According to the ministry, Cypriot investments in India span several sectors, including services, software and hardware, automobiles, manufacturing, cargo handling, construction, shipping, and pharmaceuticals.

Defence and maritime cooperation have also emerged as important pillars of bilateral engagement. George noted that the Bilateral Defence Cooperation Programme 2026 was signed in Nicosia, providing a structured framework for enhancing

defence collaboration between the two countries.

President Christodoulides, whose country currently holds the presidency of the Council of the European Union, emphasised Cyprus’s role as a strategic bridge between India and the European Union. He also expressed strong support for the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC), which aims to strengthen connectivity and trade links across regions.

The expansion of UPI into Cyprus marks another milestone in India’s efforts to internationalise its digital payment ecosystem and deepen economic partnerships globally.

Jhalmuri vendor faces death threats after viral PM meet

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The jhalmuri seller from Bengal who turned into an overnight sensation after Prime Minister Narendra Modi bought one of the State’s most popular snacks from his stall during an election rally is now allegedly receiving bomb and death threats from Pakistani and Bangladeshi numbers.

Bikram Sau, who runs a modest roadside stall in Jhargram, shot to fame on April 19 when PM Modi’s convoy made an unscheduled stop during the high-voltage West Bengal Assembly election campaign.

The Prime Minister stepped out, chatted briefly with Sau about his family, education and daily life, and paid ₹10 for a packet of jhalmuri, the iconic Bengali mix of puffed rice tossed with mustard oil, onions, peanuts, green chillies and spices.

The warm, unscripted interaction was captured on video and quickly went viral, drawing national media to the small stall and turning the humble vendor into a minor celebrity.

Sau, originally from Gaya in Bihar and now long settled in



Jhargram with his family, had been selling the snack for years, earning a modest ₹1,000-1,200 a day. After Modi’s visit on (specific date if known), everything changed overnight: television crews and social media influencers thronged his shop, turning the jhalmuri moment into a brief political flashpoint as Trinamool Congress leaders dismissed it as “scripted drama.”

What began as a feel-good campaign story has, in recent days, taken a darker turn. Sau says that since the recent time-frame, he has received repeat-

ing threatening phone and video calls from numbers linked to Pakistan and Bangladesh, with callers allegedly abusing him, displaying weapons on camera, and issuing direct threats to blow up his stall and kill him.

“I am getting repeated threat calls. They are threatening to blow me up with bombs,” Sau told news agencies. “I am afraid for my life.” He added that his family is now living in fear.

Local police registered a complaint and began investigating the cross-border calls earlier this week. As authorities now

scrutinise the numbers and trace the origin of the threats, security for Sau and his stall is currently under consideration.

This episode has sparked concern about the perils of sudden public attention in a polarised political climate.

Though harassed, Sau continues to run his stall, but the joy from his brief brush with fame has given way to anxiety. Jhalmuri remains a beloved everyday snack across Bengal; for one vendor, however, it has become a symbol of how quickly celebrity can invite danger.

2 lakh new M-PACS, White Revolution 2.0 reviewed in Raipur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Ministry of Cooperation on Friday conducted a high-level regional workshop in Raipur, Chhattisgarh, to review the progress of the ambitious project to establish two lakh new multipurpose cooperative societies, the execution of the World’s Largest Grain Storage Plan, and the roll-out of White Revolution 2.0.

The workshop saw active participation from senior administrative officials representing Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, Odisha, and West Bengal, alongside key institutional stakeholders, including NABARD, the Food Corporation of India (FCI), NAFED, NCCF, the National Dairy Development Board (NDDB), and various State warehousing corporations.

Addressing the delegates, Dr Ashish Kumar Bhutani, Secretary, Ministry of Cooperation, described the cooperative sector as the definitive “backbone of the rural economy.” Highlighting the successful precedents of dairy cooperatives in States



like Gujarat, Dr Bhutani stated that White Revolution 2.0 holds immense potential to unlock economic prosperity across Eastern and Central India, leveraging the region’s abundant water resources, fertile land, and substantial livestock.

“The Central Government is fully committed to extending every possible support to the States, and coordination at the highest level will be ensured to drive these rural initiatives forward,” Dr Bhutani asserted, urging participating States to collectively resolve ground-level operational bottlenecks.

A central focus of the deliberations was the target to establish 75,000 new Dairy Cooperative Societies (DCS) and strengthen 46,000 exist-

ing ones over the next five years. Officials emphasised that the modern dairy movement has effectively transformed rural women from homemakers into financial entrepreneurs. By gaining direct access to organised markets, financial inclusion, and decision-making platforms, women are fundamentally reorganising the grassroots cooperative financial ecosystem.

“The dairy ecosystem must expand beyond milk production into bio-gas, organic fertilisers, whey protein, and carbon credits to insulate rural livelihoods from global energy crises,” the Ministry noted during the technical sessions.

Against the backdrop of ongoing global energy imbal-

ances, supply-chain disruptions, and economic uncertainties, the Ministry strongly advocated for sustainability and circular economy models within the cooperative architecture. Delegates were urged to adopt Compressed Bio Gas (CBG) infrastructure and GOBARdhan-based frameworks to enhance India’s energy security and reduce dependence on imported resources.

Dr CR Prasanna, Secretary of the Cooperation Department in Chhattisgarh, welcomed the initiative and highlighted that the State administration is prioritizing grain storage infrastructure, bio-gas ventures, and dairy development.

The technical sessions of the workshop also scrutinized the onboarding of Primary Agricultural Credit Societies (PACS) under the Warehousing Development and Regulatory Authority (WDRA) framework, the revival of non-functional cooperative bodies, and strategic export promotion through the National Cooperative Exports Limited (NCEL).

High Commissioner-designate Dinesh Trivedi holds talks with Army Chief



ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Indian High Commissioner-designate to Bangladesh, Dinesh Trivedi, met Chief of Army Staff General Upendra Dwivedi to discuss key bilateral issues, including border security and military-to-military cooperation between India and Bangladesh.

According to a statement shared by the Indian Army on Friday, the interaction focused on “strengthening India-Bangladesh defence ties, border security and enhancing military-to-military engagement.”

Diplomatic sources confirmed that the meeting took place on Thursday,

ahead of Trivedi assuming his new diplomatic assignment in Dhaka.

On April 27, India’s Ministry of External Affairs announced the appointment of Dinesh Trivedi as the next High Commissioner of India to Bangladesh.

He is expected to take up the post shortly, likely in early June, according to diplomatic sources.

Outgoing Indian High Commissioner to Bangladesh, Pranay Verma, has been appointed as India’s next Ambassador to the Kingdom of Belgium and the European Union.

He is expected to travel directly from Dhaka to

Brussels later this month. Dinesh Trivedi previously served as Union Minister for Railways and Minister of State for Health and Family Welfare during the UPA Government while representing the Mamata Banerjee-led All India Trinamool Congress.

He resigned from the Trinamool Congress in February 2021 and later joined the Bharatiya Janata Party in March 2021.

The meeting comes at a time when India and Bangladesh continue to engage closely on regional security, border management and strategic cooperation in South Asia.

Union Govt sets October 31 target to map legacy waste sites

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Jal Jeevan Mission currently covers around 5.91 lakh villages, 2.62 lakh gram panchayats, more than 16 lakh habitations and over 19.41 crore rural households, benefitting nearly 96 crore people across the country, the Jal Shakti Ministry said on Friday.

Jal Shakti officials also said districts have been directed to identify all legacy waste sites by October 31 and ensure remediation within prescribed timelines under the Solid Waste Management Rules, 2026.

The information was shared during a nationwide review meeting convened by the Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation (DDWS) with over 759 deputy commissioners, district magistrates and collectors to review the implementation of Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM) 2.0 and enforcement of the Solid Waste Management Rules, 2026 in rural areas.

■ States Focus ■

West Bengal Tribunals clear 0.26% of 25 lakh voter appeals



PURI RATH YATRA: SPECIAL SOP TO FOCUSES ON CROWD CONTROL

The Odisha Police are focusing on crowd management, traffic regulation and deployment of a specialised force during the annual Rath Yatra in Puri to prevent a repeat of last year's stampede in which three devotees were killed, officials said on Friday.

DGP Y B Khurania held a high-level meeting at the state police headquarters in Cuttack on Thursday to finalise a special Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) for the nine-day festival beginning July 16, they said.

"All aspects – beginning from crowd management, vehicle parking, smooth movement of devotees, health facilities in the wake of the hot and humid weather conditions, to security arrangements – are part of the SOP, which would be strictly followed," said a senior official who is in charge of the Rath Yatra festival this year.



Police personnel present at the site as the West Bengal Railway Hawkers' Union (CITU) members stage a protest against the alleged forcible eviction of hawkers and 'bulldozer culture' by the BJP in West Bengal, at Sealdah Railway Station in Kolkata on Friday

KOLKATA HAWKERS PROTEST STATION EVICTION

Hawkers affiliated to CITU-allied West Bengal Railway Hawkers' Union held a protest in front of Sealdah railway station in Kolkata against their removal from the premises and surrounding areas.

The railway authorities, with assistance from the police, are holding anti-encroachment drives at various stations, including Howrah and Sealdah.

Claiming that the hawkers have been left without livelihood, the union demanded their rehabilitation.

In a bid to clear the platforms and other surrounding areas at railway stations of encroachment to make movement of passengers hassle-free, the railways resorted to the eviction of hawkers, officials said.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The SIR-linked appellate tribunals in West Bengal have disposed of only 6,581 cases, around 0.26 per cent of the nearly 25 lakh appeals filed against decisions taken by judicial officers during the electoral roll revision exercise, official data showed on Thursday.

Of the cases decided by 12 of the 19 tribunals till May 14, 4,043 appeals were allowed, meaning names of nearly 61.5 per cent of disposed cases made it back to the electoral rolls, while 1,267 were rejected, according to the ECI data.

The status of over 1,200

remaining cases among the disposed matters was not immediately clear from the data. The tribunals were constituted on March 20, following Supreme Court directions to establish an appellate mechanism for grievances arising out of judicial officers' decisions during the revision process.

Kolkata North and Kolkata South together accounted for 1,777 disposals, around 27 per cent of the total cases decided so far.

The tribunal handling the two electoral districts was headed by retired Calcutta High Court Chief Justice TS Sivagnanam, who resigned on May 7, citing personal reasons. More than 51,000



appeals remain pending in the two districts.

Murshidabad and Malda, which recorded large numbers of appeals and deletions during the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls, reported comparatively low disposal figures.

Murshidabad saw 112 appeals disposed of out of more than 6.29 lakh filed, while Malda recorded 185 disposals against over 5.26 lakh pleas.

According to officials, hearings were conducted through both online and offline

West Bengal Govt begins verification for Annapurna Yojana

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The West Bengal Government has launched a verification and database-cleansing exercise for beneficiaries of the upcoming Annapurna Yojana, directing district administrations to complete the process before the scheme is rolled out on June 1, an official said on Friday.

According to an official order issued by the Women and Child Development and Social Welfare Department, the exercise aims to identify and remove ineligible names from the beneficiary database and ensure proper authentication of genuine recipients.

The West Bengal Government, on May 19, notified the Annapurna Yojana financial assistance scheme for women, replacing the existing 'Lakshmi Bhandar' programme, for a monthly



allowance of ₹3,000, which will take effect from June 1.

"All existing beneficiaries of 'Lakshmi Bhandar' scheme shall be migrated to the Annapurna Yojana except the dead, shifted, deleted and absentee electors identified during SIR-2026, deletion in the second list after publication of draft list, deleted after adjudication, ASDD (Absent, Shifted, Dead, or Duplicate) found during voter slip distribution," the notification said.

BJP circulates posters of missing J&K CM Omar Abdullah

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

The Jammu and Kashmir unit of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has circulated a poster on social media claiming that Chief Minister Omar Abdullah has been missing since May 11. The main Opposition party has also appealed to the general masses to share any information about his whereabouts.

After May 13, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah has not been seen publicly attending any Government or private function. Omar Abdullah had chaired a meeting of the council of ministers in Srinagar on May 13.

A detailed press note was circulated by the Department of Information and Public Relations, highlighting the decisions taken

during the meeting. Despite Omar Abdullah's absence, the official handle of the Office of the Chief Minister has been sharing regular updates on X.

Chief Minister Omar Abdullah's absence was noticed during a major demolition drive in Jammu to evict encroachers. The manner in which the drive was launched in the wee hours of May 19 triggered a political backlash, prompting the top brass of the National Conference to launch a massive damage control.

Several senior party leaders, including elected representatives of the party and the Minister in charge of the Forest Department, visited the affected Gujar and Bakarwal families living in the area, but failed to pacify them.



To save their skin, the popular Government has already ordered an inquiry into the violation of the

Forest Rights Act during a demolition drive in Jammu.

Meanwhile, reacting to the posters, National Conference president Farooq Abdullah hit back at the BJP on Friday, saying the saffron party has "nothing better" to do. "They have their own campaigns, they know what they are doing. We don't have to answer them," the senior Abdullah told reporters after offering the congregational prayers at the Hazratbal shrine in Jammu.

Farooq also brushed aside rumours of a split in alliance with the Congress in Jammu and Kashmir. "I think it is our enemies who are saying all this. The alliance is there, nothing will happen," he said.

On the row over the recent demolition of homes of Gujar and

Bakarwal families in Jammu's Sidhra area, the NC president said his party or the State Government had no role.

"We are not involved in that. They (the lieutenant governor) have done it, and an investigation is going on. It is not just in Sidhra, but also in other places in Jammu, where such attacks have taken place on Gujar. They don't understand that these people were the biggest sympathisers on the borders, he said.

To the Opposition, PDP's charge that the J&K Government was following UP CM Yogi Adityanath's model, Abdullah lashed out at them, saying, "They are the ones who created this mess." "They ended Article 370 and 35A. They are responsible for the destruction of our State," Farooq claimed.

West Bengal announces free bus travel for women from June 1

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The West Bengal Government has notified free bus travel for women in all State Government-run buses from June 1 as part of a scheme aimed at enhancing women's empowerment and improving access to public transport.



According to a notification issued by the State Transport Department on May 21, women commuters will be eligible for free travel in both short-route and long-route State-run buses operating in West Bengal.

The Transport department notification said a smart card with QR code, photograph and beneficiary details will be issued to all eligible women upon application through the BDO or SDO offices concerned.

Attacks on cops rise amid crackdown on criminals: Bihar Police

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Bihar Police on Friday claimed that attacks on its personnel have increased amidst an intensified crackdown on criminals, forcing officers to open fire in self-defence in some cases.

Rejecting allegations that police encounters were being carried out on the basis of caste, newly appointed additional director general of police (law and order) Sudhanshu Kumar asserted that law enforcement agencies do not differentiate on caste lines.

"Police have no caste, and neither do criminals. For criminals who attack police personnel, we will not ask their caste before taking action against them to save our lives," Kumar told reporters at the police headquarters in Patna.

He said sustained action by police, including arrests, speedy trials and seizure of properties acquired through crime, had led to desperation among criminal elements.

"In the wake of arrests, speedy trials and seizure of property acquired through crime, it is natural that some



desperate elements will take such steps as attacking police, but we are ready for that," he said.

The ADGP said Bihar Police identified 1,433 criminals under provisions related to seizure of illegally acquired

properties between January and May 15, and proposals against 428 people were sent to courts during the period.

Proceedings for seizure of property are underway against 103 accused, while attachment orders have been issued against four others, he added.

Kumar said 33,126 accused were arrested between January and May 15 in serious criminal cases, including murder (2,023), dacoity (311), loot (573) and atrocities against Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (1,572).

Opposition slams Telangana Govt over crop procurement delays

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

Criticising the Congress Government in Telangana over the alleged delay in crop purchases, the Opposition parties-BJP, BRS, and TRS-on Friday urged the Government to buy farmers' produce without further delay.

Referring to Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy's remarks on Thursday that 80 per cent of the produce had been procured from farmers, BRS working president KT Rama Rao said no paddy procurement centre was functioning properly.

He told reporters that he



was ready to face any punishment if it was proven that 80 per cent of the procurement had indeed been completed.

He alleged that farmers

had been waiting for the last 45 days for their crops to be procured. The ryots were facing several hardships, as they had to pay for gunny

bags and tractor waiting charges, he claimed, adding that even drinking water was unavailable at the centres.

The BRS leader demanded that the Congress Government release a crop-wise white paper detailing procurement carried out so far during the current Rabi season.

Referring to the CM's recent comments that Congress would win the next Assembly elections in 2028 and that he would continue for a second term, Rama Rao said that if Reddy was confident of Congress being re-elected, both BRS and Congress should seek a fresh mandate from the people.

Activists seek protection of 23,000 wetlands in Maharashtra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane

On International Day for Biological Diversity on Friday, environmentalists urged Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis to fast-track legal protection for over 23,000 wetlands across the State, warning that further delay will worsen biodiversity loss and climate vulnerability.

The National Centre for Sustainable Coastal Management (NCSCM) has completed documentation and ground verification for



23,404 out of Maharashtra's 23,415 identified wetlands, leaving only 11 sites in Pune district pending, these environmentalists said.

The verified data will now move to district administrations and the State Wetland Authority for final legal noti-

transparency in the voters' list," the official said. The Supreme Court had on February 20 directed judicial intervention in the revision exercise, observing a trust deficit between the ECI and the then West Bengal Government over the preparation of electoral rolls.

Acting on the apex court's directions, the Calcutta High Court recommended around 700 judicial officers to examine cases flagged during the revision process.

These officers scrutinised appeals of more than 60 lakh electors identified through the ECI's verification process for alleged inconsistencies in identity-related documents.

youth with new opportunities in the AI sector at the global level," he said.

The event, themed "India: AI in Action", will showcase practical applications of AI across industries.

TEAM co-chair and governing council member Harsh Jain said Mumbai Tech Week 2026 would focus not only on discussions but also on demonstrating how AI is transforming industries and creating economic opportunities.

"With the Maharashtra Government as our partner, we have an opportunity to make this a landmark moment for Mumbai and Maharashtra's AI economy," Jain said.

He said the event would also host AI Excellence Awards 2026, an early-stage startup showcase and an AI-based job fair.

More than 25 companies are expected to participate in the recruitment drive, offering over 250 job opportunities to more than 30,000 candidates, he said.

India to host Quad Foreign Ministers' meet on May 26



ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

India will host the upcoming Quad Foreign Ministers' meeting in New Delhi on May 26, bringing together senior diplomats from Australia, Japan and the United States to discuss regional and global developments and deepen cooperation in the Indo-Pacific region.

The meeting will be convened at the invitation of External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar. Australian Foreign Minister Penny Wong, Japanese Foreign Minister Toshimitsu Motegi and US Secretary of State Marco Rubio are expected to participate in the ministerial dialogue in the national Capital.

According to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), the ministers will continue discussions held during the previous Quad meeting in Washington, DC, on July 1, 2025, in line with the grouping's vision for a "Free and Open Indo-Pacific."

"The Ministers will exchange views on advancing Quad cooperation across priority areas, review progress on ongoing Quad initiatives, and reflect on recent developments in the Indo-Pacific region and other international issues of mutual concern," the MEA said in a statement.

The Quad – comprising India, Australia, Japan and the United States – has emerged as a key strategic forum focused on ensuring peace, stability and prosperity in the Indo-Pacific region.

During their visit to New Delhi, the foreign ministers of Australia and Japan, along with the US Secretary of State, are also expected to hold bilateral meetings with Jaishankar and call on Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the MEA added. US Secretary of State Marco Rubio will visit India from May 23 to 26 in his first official trip to the country since assuming office as US Secretary of State and National Security Adviser.

fication under the Wetlands Rules, they added.

The NCSCM's expedited verification follows Supreme Court directives on a petition by NGO Vanashakti, urging time-bound demarcation to mitigate extreme weather impacts.

India needs innovators, not interpreters: Dharmendra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Friday defended the emphasis on Indian languages in the education system, saying India needs “innovators, not interpreters”, while asserting that foreign languages should not become a burden for students.

Addressing the Jagran Bharat Education Conclave 2026, Pradhan expressed his support for teaching foreign languages, noting that students involved in global trade should learn multiple foreign languages.

“I am in favour of teaching foreign languages. Those who will handle Indian trade and commerce in global markets should learn even five foreign languages,” the minister said. However, he stressed that students should study in the language in which they understand concepts best.

“When a child needs clarity, they should not remain burdened with foreign languages. They should study in the language in which they understand concepts clearly,” he said.



Pradhan cited a review by the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE), which found that only one per cent of the board’s total student population is studying foreign languages.

“We conducted a review through CBSE and found that foreign language students constitute only one per cent of the total student population,” he said.

Responding to criticism over the emphasis on Indian languages, the minister said that India’s rapid growth in innovation, research and manufacturing requires creators and innovators rather than translators.

“Indian languages should be studied because India has rapidly advanced in innovation over the past 10 years. Our production, research and national requirements have grown. India now has a population of 140 crore, and the Global South is increasingly connected with India. The expectations of the Global South rest on India’s research, innovation and low-cost production value chain,” he said.

He emphasised that to strengthen India’s innovation and low-cost production ecosystem, the nation needs more innovators than interpreters. “A few interpreters will always be

needed, but society must decide whether it wants innovators or interpreters,” he added.

“Our education policy is moving towards creating innovators,” the minister said. Pradhan welcomed criticism in a democracy as long as it is logical and relevant. “Criticism is essential in a democracy. But criticism should be logical and relevant - it should help take the debate forward,” he added.

On Friday, the Supreme Court said it will hear a plea next week challenging the new CBSE policy, which has made the study of three languages, including at least two native Indian languages, compulsory for Class 9 students beginning July 1.

Senior advocate Mukul Rohatgi mentioned the matter before a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi.

“This is an urgent PIL. The petitioners are students, teachers and parents. They are challenging the new policy of the CBSE by which, in the 9th standard, two more languages have been made compulsory,” Rohatgi said.

Union Govt asks States to step up vigil over Ebola outbreak

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Union Health Ministry has asked all States and Union territories to step up surveillance, hospital preparedness and screening of international travellers following the WHO’s declaration of the Ebola outbreak in the Democratic Republic of Congo and Uganda as a public health emergency of international concern (PHEIC).

In a letter to chief secretaries and administrators of UTs on May 21, Union Health Secretary Punya Salila Srivastava said countries bordering DRC and Uganda, including South Sudan, have been assessed to be at high risk of disease transmission.

“While the current assessment indicates that the risk to countries outside the affected African region remains low, the substantial quantum of international trade and travel underscores the importance of maintaining adequate preparedness and response capacities at all levels of the health system,” the letter said.

The ministry directed States to strengthen surveil-



lance under the Integrated Disease Surveillance Programme (IDSP) for unusual clusters of cases showing symptoms suggestive of Ebola disease, particularly among people with recent travel history to affected areas.

The symptoms listed in the advisory include fever, weakness, muscle pain, headache, sore throat, vomiting, diarrhoea, stomach pain, rash and red eyes.

States have also been asked to identify designated isolation facilities and dedicated ambulances, ensure availability of trained healthcare personnel, personal protective equipment (PPE), logistics,

laboratory support and critical care capacities.

The ministry said ICMR’s National Institute of Virology (NIV), Pune, is fully equipped to test samples from suspected Ebola cases detected either at points of entry or in the community, and additional ICMR network laboratories would be strengthened depending on the evolving situation.

The advisory stressed coordination among airport and port health authorities, state and district surveillance units and other agencies for prompt information sharing and follow-up of travellers requiring public health monitoring.



CENTRE CURBS PREGABALIN MISUSE, MOVES IT TO H1 CATEGORY

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Union Health Ministry has brought pregabalin, a drug used for treating chronic pain and certain neurological conditions, under the stricter Schedule H1 category amid reports of its misuse and abuse. The ministry notified the inclusion of pregabalin under Schedule H1 of the Drugs Rules, 1945, through a gazette notification on May 20.

“The decision has been taken in view of reports received from certain States regarding the misuse and abuse of Pregabalin, particularly among youth,” the ministry said.

The drug, which is prescribed for the treatment of chronic pain, neuropathies, fibromyalgia, and certain neurological conditions, has reportedly been misused for its sedative, euphoric, and dissociative effects.

The ministry cited seizures of illegal stocks and sales of pregabalin in parts of the country.

The medicine was earlier regulated under Schedule H under the Drugs and Cosmetics Rules, 1945.

Under the revised classification, the drug can now be sold only against a valid prescription issued by a registered medical practitioner (RMP).

Retailers will now have to maintain a separate register recording details of prescriptions and sales, while manufacturers must prominently display the prescribed ‘Schedule H1 Drug Warning’ label on product packaging, a ministry statement said.

The ministry said violations and non-compliance would attract penal action under the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940, and related rules.

According to the statement, the move is aimed at “strengthening accountability across the supply chain, preventing unauthorised access, enhancing prescription monitoring, curbing illegal trafficking, and safeguarding public health from drug misuse and abuse.”

Gujarat jails overcrowded; State ranks high in parole jumps

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Gujarat’s prison system is facing mounting pressure due to overcrowding and a rising number of parole jump cases, according to recent prison statistics. The State has also emerged among the top States in the country in terms of convicts awarded death sentences and the proportion of life-term prisoners.

Data shows that Gujarat had 49 prisoners on death row, the second-highest figure in the country after Uttar Pradesh, 141. Maharashtra reported 43 such convicts, while Madhya Pradesh and Kerala recorded 35 each.

Among the 5,231 convicted inmates lodged in Gujarat prisons, nearly two-thirds were serving life imprisonment. The share of life convicts in the State remained significantly above the national average, placing Gujarat among the top states in this category.

Under-trial prisoners formed the largest segment of the prison population, followed by convicted inmates and detainees. The report also highlighted that nearly 90 per cent of both convict-



ed and under-trial inmates had educational qualifications only up to Class 12.

The prison population included inmates from outside Gujarat as well as foreign nationals. Hundreds of convicts and undertrials belonged to other Indian States, while several foreign nationals were also lodged in jails across Gujarat.

A demographic analysis revealed that a majority of both convicts and under-trial prisoners were below the age of 50. The report further

noted that women inmates were living in prisons along with children, including convicted and under-trial women caring for infants and young children behind bars.

Among foreign convicts, Pakistani nationals accounted for the highest number in Gujarat prisons, followed by inmates from Bangladesh, African nations, West Asian countries and Nigeria. Similar trends were observed among under-trial foreign prisoners, with Pakistani nationals forming the largest group.

Security for Eid-ul-Azha, Amarnath Yatra reviewed in J&K

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar

Kashmir Police chief VK Birdi on Friday reviewed security and logistical arrangements for the upcoming Eid-ul-Azha and the annual Amarnath yatra, a police spokesperson said.

During a meeting at PCR Kashmir, district SSPs gave detailed presentations on security preparedness, deployment plans, traffic regulation, crowd management measures, and other logistical arrangements for Eid-ul-Azha celebrations and the annual Shri



Amarnath ji Yatra (SANJY), the spokesperson said.

Highlighting the significance of the Eid celebrations, Birdi, the Inspector General of Police (IGP) Kashmir Zone, directed offi-

cers to implement robust crowd management measures at mosques and major congregation points across the Valley.

Birdi emphasised the need for adequate security measures to regulate entry and exit points, ensure

public safety, and deploy security personnel at sensitive locations to avoid overcrowding, the spokesperson said. He said the IGP also instructed field officers to intensify surveillance, conduct random checks at vulnerable spots, and enhance patrolling to counter any potential security threats during the festive period.

Reviewing arrangements for the yatra, the IGP emphasised coordinated planning and preparedness, particularly regarding the safety and security of the yatrīs, the spokesperson said.

138th OSCC meeting reviews offshore security

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The 138th Offshore Security Coordination Committee (OSCC) meeting was held in Ahmedabad on Thursday under the Chairpersonship of Director General Indian Coast Guard, Paramesh Sivamani, to review and strengthen the security framework for India’s offshore installations and critical energy infrastructure, the Defence Ministry said on Friday.

Giving details, it said the Committee focused on enhancing maritime domain awareness, strengthening inter-agency coordination, augmenting surveillance capabilities and improving joint response mecha-



nisms to effectively address emerging offshore security challenges.

During the meeting, deliberations were held on the evolving global and regional security environment, modern warfare dynamics, including unmanned and drone-enabled

threats, and the expanding offshore exploration activities in the Andaman & Nicobar region.

The meeting was attended by representatives from the Indian Coast Guard (ICG), Indian Navy, Indian Air Force, Ministry of Home Affairs, Ministry of External Affairs, Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, Director General Hydrographer, DG Shipping, Intelligence Bureau, Oil and Natural Gas Commission and State Police forces.

The meeting reaffirmed the commitment of all stakeholders towards ensuring robust security of India’s offshore assets and critical maritime infrastructure.

Bihar Govt transfers, gives extra charges to several IAS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Patna

The Bihar Government on Friday transferred and assigned additional responsibilities to several IAS officers. According to a notification by the general administration department, 1992-batch IAS officer Deepak Kumar Singh has been appointed principal secretary to the Governor.

Arvind Kumar Choudhary, a 1995-batch IAS officer and additional chief secretary in the cabinet secretariat department, has been relieved of the additional charge of the home department, the notification said.



Deepak Kumar Singh

Kundan Kumar, a 2004-batch IAS officer currently serving as secretary in the industries department, has been given additional charge of the home department, while Sanjay Kumar Singh (IAS-2007), who is currently holding the post of secretary, finance department, has been given additional charge of vigilance commissioner, general administration department, the notification said.



Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Friday inaugurated the landmark Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee Flyover in Guwahati

PIONEER PHOTO

ED arrests Hyderabad Ponzi scheme accused from Gurugram

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Friday said it has arrested Nowhera Shaik, the prime accused in the Heera Group-linked alleged investment fraud in Hyderabad, from an Airbnb property in Gurugram.

Shaik was arrested on Thursday during a joint operation conducted by the ED and the Haryana Police at the facility in Sector 45, Gurugram.

The ED said in a statement that she was living in Gurugram under a “fake” identity, using “forged” documents (Aadhaar) in the name of Shaik Khamar Jahan. She was apprehended from an Airbnb property along with an associate, Sameer Khan, it added.

The agency said Shaik was taken to Hyderabad on Friday and produced before a special PMLA court that sent her to judicial custody.

Shaik, the Heera Group of Companies and others



Nowhera Shaik

Jagan Reddy launches fierce attack on Andhra Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amravati

Andhra Pradesh former chief minister and YSR Congress Party president YS Jagan Mohan Reddy launched a scathing attack on the Government led by Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu, accusing it of failing on governance, welfare, law and order, and financial management during its two years in office.

Addressing party leaders and supporters in Tadepalli, Jagan alleged that the State administration had become synonymous with “broken promises, corruption, suppression of dissent, and propaganda-driven governance.” He claimed that



people were struggling with rising living costs and economic uncertainty, while the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) Government had abandoned its election assurances.

Calling the present situation “Jungle Raj,” he remarked that “Babu surety - cheating guarantee” was

being proven true every day. Jagan strongly criticised the Amaravati Capital development project, warning that it could push Andhra Pradesh into a severe debt trap. He said the proposed MAVIGAN Capital Corridor, linking Machilipatnam, Vijayawada, and Gannavaram, was a more practical and financially sustainable alternative due to its existing infrastructure network.

According to him, Amaravati would require nearly ₹2 lakh crore for basic infrastructure, while borrowings and commitments linked to the project had already crossed ₹47,000 crore. The YSRCP chief also targeted the Government over law-and-order issues,

alleging misuse of police machinery, political vendetta, and intimidation of Opposition leaders and supporters.

He accused the Government of filing FIRs and pressuring social media platforms to remove content related to alleged corruption and irregularities. Jagan further alleged that welfare schemes for women, students, SCs, STs, BCs, minorities, and unemployed youth had been neglected. Concluding his remarks, he said YSRCP governance focused on welfare, healthcare, education, and transparency, while the present administration thrived on “propaganda, debt, and broken promises.”

The Supreme Court to auction the properties so that the funds derived from those can be restituted to the victims in accordance with a PMLA provision.

Some of the properties were successfully auctioned, fetching about ₹122 crore, according to the ED.

However, Shaik failed to cooperate in the execution of sale deeds in favour of successful bidders and made repeated attempts to obstruct the auction proceedings, the agency alleged.

allegedly collected more than ₹5,978 crore from the public, promising returns exceeding 36 per cent per annum. However, they failed to return even the principal amount, thereby duping more than 1.72 lakh gullible investors of ₹3,000 crore, the ED said.

The agency said Shaik was “evading” investigation and arrest in the case since the Supreme Court recently cancelled her bail after taking “serious note of her conduct during which she

misled” the apex court.

A special court in Hyderabad dealing with cases lodged under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) issued a non-bailable warrant against her on May 7, but she was not traceable at her Hyderabad and Bengaluru addresses, the ED said.

An intelligence input indicated she was in Gurugram, it added. The federal agency had attached assets worth ₹428 crore in the case and obtained a green signal from



Editor's
TAKE

Xi-Putin meet: A new axis in the making?

Days after hosting Donald Trump, Chinese President Xi Jinping welcomed Russian President Vladimir Putin, reinforcing China's emergence as a global power

There is a certain theatre to summitry, and Beijing staged it masterfully. First Donald Trump arrived, then Vladimir Putin - each travelling thousands of miles to sit across from Xi Jinping in Beijing, now at the centre of geopolitics. The optics were unmistakable: China is now the world's indispensable interlocutor, and Xi its undisputed convener-in-chief.

The agenda of the Xi-Putin summit, held on Wednesday, was broad in scope and strategic in intent. The two leaders signed documents spanning trade, technology, scientific research and intellectual property, while extending their foundational treaty of "good neighbourliness and friendly cooperation" - first inked a quarter of a century ago. They spoke warmly of cooperation in artificial intelligence and even the conservation of rare tigers and pandas. But beneath the ceremonial warmth lay substance that matters greatly for the rest of the world.

"The global agenda of peace and development is facing new risks and challenges, with the danger of fragmentation of the international community," the Xi-Putin joint declaration stated in clear terms. The centrepiece of their joint statement was a pointed condemnation of United States. Both leaders warned of a world drifting back towards the "law of the jungle" - a deliberate rebuke of American foreign policy, directed squarely at the Trump administration's unilateralism, its pursuit of a "golden dome" missile defence system, and its decision to allow a nuclear arms treaty to lapse in February. Whatever the diplomatic niceties, this amounted to a declaration of an alternative world order - one centred on Beijing.

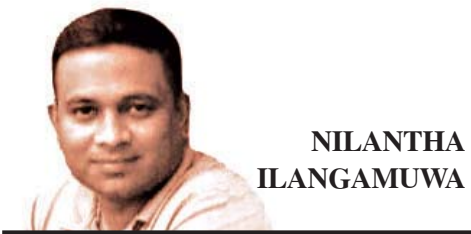
Yet the summit also revealed limits. Russia and China failed to finalise a long-anticipated gas pipeline agreement that would have doubled Moscow's fossil fuel exports eastward. Pricing disagreements reportedly blocked a deal - a reminder that even the warmest partnerships have hard commercial edges. Currently, China sits at the forefront of global geopolitics. It can pick and choose partners and dictate the terms of engagement. Putin needs China far more than China needs Russia, and Beijing knows how to use that leverage quietly. However, it is unmistakable that the two powers are drawing closer, and the synergy is evident.

First, the Russia-China axis has deepened beyond rhetoric: from military exercises to - according to European intelligence agencies - covert training of Russian soldiers, Beijing's "official neutrality" on Ukraine is increasingly difficult to sustain as credible. Second, Xi's carefully choreographed reception of both Trump and Putin in the same week underlines China's rare position as a power that neither United States nor Russia can afford to alienate. Third, and perhaps most consequentially, the joint warning against American "unilateral bullying" signals that Beijing and Moscow intend to shape the architecture of whatever post-American international order may be emerging together.

Whether the world should find that prospect stabilising or alarming is, perhaps, the defining geopolitical question of our era.

The slow death of peacekeeping

The peacekeeping system the world built to prevent its worst instincts from running unchecked is dying — not in a single dramatic moment, but through the slow bleed of empty budgets, absent troops and political indifference



NILANTHA
ILANGAMUWA

The international system built to keep the world's most fragile regions from descending into chaos is quietly falling apart. Not through dramatic collapse, but through slow, steady exhaustion — shrinking budgets, fewer troops, weakened mandates and fading political will. A forthcoming report from the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI) lays bare the scale of this retreat: personnel deployed to peace operations worldwide have fallen to just 78,633, the lowest figure in at least 25 years and barely half the number seen in 2016.

This is no temporary setback or administrative hiccup. It is evidence of a structural contraction in the willingness of states to honour their collective security commitments - a signal that the multilateral ideals underpinning modern peacekeeping are losing their grip on the real world.

From optimism to exhaustion

Peacekeeping operations once embodied the defining optimism of the post-Cold War era. The belief that nations could set aside their rivalries and cooperate through international institutions to contain conflict and protect civilians seemed, for a time, genuinely achievable. That belief is now badly depleted. What survives is the shell of a once-ambitious system - kept alive more by institutional inertia than by any coherent strategic vision.

The United Nations, at the centre of this system, is operating under severe financial and political strain. SIPRI points to persistent liquidity shortfalls driven by delayed or unpaid contributions from major member states. A funding gap approaching two billion dollars within a single peacekeeping cycle is not merely an accounting problem — it is a political statement. It signals that several influential powers no longer regard collective security as an urgent shared responsibility.

International leaders continue to invoke the language of solidarity and multilateralism at global forums. But the practical foundations that once gave those words meaning are weakening. The gap between rhetoric and operational reality has become impossible to ignore.

A council that can no longer agree

Much of this paralysis flows from the United Nations Security Council, originally designed as the stabilising core of the post-war inter-



KOFI ANNAN, IN ONE OF HIS FINAL INTERVIEWS BEFORE HIS DEATH IN 2018, DESCRIBED HIMSELF AS A "STUBBORN OPTIMIST" AND INSISTED THAT INTERNATIONAL COOPERATION REMAINED INDISPENSABLE. HE ARGUED THAT THERE COULD BE NO SECURITY WITHOUT DEVELOPMENT, NO DEVELOPMENT WITHOUT SECURITY, AND NEITHER WITHOUT HUMAN RIGHTS

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purpose and accountability.

A model built for a different world

The conceptual crisis runs as deep as the operational one. Modern peacekeeping was built on assumptions that no longer reliably hold — that external forces could stabilise conflicts where all parties retained some interest in restraint, and that armed groups would respect international presence even without coercive backing. In today's most volatile conflict zones, those assumptions are routinely confounded. Armed actors indifferent to international norms are unlikely to be deterred by lightly equipped missions operating under restrictive mandates.

Meanwhile, those mandates have grown ever more ambitious — encompassing civilian protection, governance support, human rights monitoring and counterterrorism assistance — while the political backing required to deliver on such expansive responsibilities has steadily eroded. Missions are asked to stabilise increasingly complex crises without adequate resources, military capability or diplomatic consensus. The result is peacekeeping that risks becoming little more than a symbolic presence.

The erosion of a shared belief

Perhaps the most profound shift is normative. The idea that peacekeeping represents a shared moral and political obligation of the international community is losing force. States increasingly treat participation as

optional, shaped by domestic political calculations rather than enduring international duty. What is disappearing is not just funding or troops, but the underlying belief that nations - despite their rivalries — have a collective responsibility to preserve a minimum standard of human security.

Kofi Annan, in one of his final interviews before his death in 2018, described himself as a "stubborn optimist" and insisted that international cooperation remained indispensable. He argued that there could be no security without development, no development without security, and neither without human rights. That vision now feels distant. The institutions he represented still survive rhetorically, but much of their operational substance has been hollowed out.

What is ending is not peacekeeping itself, but the coherence of the global system that once gave it legitimacy and shared purpose. In its place is emerging something more selective, transactional and uneven — a fragmented landscape of interventions that may contain individual crises, but no longer reflect any unified vision of international responsibility. The decline of peacekeeping, in this sense, is also the decline of a broader idea: that the world, at its best, can still act together.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

Africa bears the cost

The human consequences of this retreat are most visible in Sub-Saharan Africa, which hosts the majority of peacekeeping missions yet is simultaneously experiencing some of the steepest reductions in deployed forces. Peacekeepers are withdrawing not because stability has been achieved, but because sustaining long-term international deployments has become politically inconvenient and financially burdensome for contributing states.

The vacuum this creates is rarely filled by calm. Instead, fragmented alternatives are filling the space: ad hoc coalitions, bilateral security arrangements and regionally limited interventions driven by narrow strategic interests rather than universal mandates. Countries such as Rwanda, United Arab Emirates and Uganda are increasingly deploying forces abroad through bilateral deals shaped by national interest and geopolitical influence. These interventions may not be illegitimate, but they differ fundamentally from traditional peacekeeping in both

Everyone wants change, but who should change first?



RAJYOGI
BRAHMA
KUMAR
NIKUNJ JI

2ND OPINION

Across the globe, almost every leader today articulates the need to base the educational system, politics, trade and commerce, and all other professions on moral and human values. But when these leaders are themselves faced with real-life situations, they discover that there are dissonances galore, even among the elite, about the right type of values and also about who should observe which values. For example, heads of many countries that are members of the United Nations or its Security Council stress the withdrawal of one powerful country's troops from a less powerful country, for it is an act of forcible occupation of another member state's territory and is against the accepted principles of international amity, cooperation, coexistence and non-covetousness. They therefore call upon powerful nations to observe moral norms and maintain the status quo ante. But those nations argue vehemently that the

United Nations Security Council and its member nations do not themselves practise the values of justice and fairness in their treatment of all countries because, if they did, they would earlier have declared military blockades and economic sanctions against many such powerful nations that have repeatedly occupied the territory of another member state illegally. Likewise, in India, those opposing reservations in many sectors argue that merit should be given the highest value and that selections and promotions

should be based on merit, for neglecting merit means placing a premium on mediocrity and turning back the wheels of progress at a time when other nations are advancing rapidly. Denying opportunities to those who deserve them on merit, they say, is an injustice to those who work hard to achieve excellence and higher standards.

On the other hand, those in favour of reservations argue that denying better opportunities to backward classes and castes is an even greater injustice. Others maintain that promoting employment prospects on the basis of caste is a negative and indirect way of encouraging casteism and of converting the present meritorious sections of society into the backward classes of tomorrow.

In a similar way, those driven by the zeal to build a place of worship at a disputed site argue that the minority should respect the sentiments of the majority and cooperate in correcting a historical wrong committed by invaders who

demolished a religious structure out of fanaticism. Those opposed to this argue that the majority community should be more liberal and magnanimous and should not revive buried conflicts that may inflame religious tensions, fear and instability.

In short, there is constant dispute over who is failing to observe which values, and yet everyone insists that grave moral degeneration has taken place. Each person raises an accusing finger at another without realising that the remaining fingers point back at themselves. The real remedy for transforming society and grounding it in cherished values lies in self-transformation and in fulfilling the responsibility of practising values in one's own life first.

Transformation, as we all know and experience ourselves, is a natural process of life filled with many ups and downs. It is a journey of self-discovery, with moments of triumph and moments of despair. A single nurtured seed grows into a fruitful tree. Imagine the world if every individual transformed positively from within. It would undoubtedly become a far better place in which to live.

Therefore, never think that only if others change will you change, because if "I" change, those around me will inevitably change too. The true process is about changing "I", not "them".

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a popular columnist

PIC TALK



A vendor arranges earthen pots fitted with taps for sale amid intense heatwave conditions during the summer season.

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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INDIA-ITALY PARTNERSHIP SIGNALS EUROPE STRATEGY SHIFT

This refers to the editorial "India Expands Its European Footprint" (May 22). The elevation of India-Italy relations to a special strategic partnership marks an important diplomatic development, though its long-term significance will depend more on implementation than symbolism. Among the many outcomes of the engagement, the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) remains the most consequential. Italy's location as a Mediterranean gateway gives it strategic importance that goes beyond diplomacy. If IMEC is to emerge as a credible alternative to China's Belt and Road Initiative, it requires committed partners with strong infrastructure and logistical capabilities, and Italy is well positioned in that regard.

The bilateral trade target of \$20 billion by 2029 is realistic, but

achieving it will require Indian industry to move beyond conventional exports and deepen cooperation in defence manufacturing, green technology and advanced industrial sectors. The opportunity is substantial, but preparedness and coordination within Indian industry will be equally important.

Even the cultural references to Rome and Varanasi carry diplomatic significance. Shared civilisational narratives help project India as more than a transactional partner and contribute towards building deeper political goodwill across Europe.

India's European outreach is finally acquiring strategic coherence and deserves sustained follow-through.

A MYLSAMI | COIMBATORE

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Ebola vigilance must continue

Apropos "Ebola scare delays India-Africa summit" (The Pioneer, May 23), the recent Ebola outbreak has understandably triggered concern worldwide. The World Health Organization has declared it a "Public Health Emergency of International Concern" (PHEIC), urging countries to strengthen surveillance and precautionary measures.

Though the outbreak has not yet reached epidemic proportions globally, the increasing number of suspected cases and deaths has placed health authorities on high alert.

The present outbreak is linked to the Bundibugyo virus (BDBV), for which no approved vaccine currently exists. Since treatment remains mainly supportive and symptomatic, anxiety in affected African nations has intensified. The situation is further complicated because many infections are being reported from conflict-hit regions, making it difficult for authorities to identify and isolate infected individuals.

Ebola symptoms include fever, headache, muscle pain, vomiting and bleeding. India has strengthened screening measures, while public awareness and timely reporting remain essential to contain the disease.

ABHILASHA GUPTA | MOHALI

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

HARSH PAWARIA | ROHTAK

When AI speaks in tribal languages: The promise of inclusive development

As technology bridges distances, as science delivers healing, as AI speaks in the languages of the forests and the hills, and as governance reaches the last family in the farthest village, we move closer each day to India that is not merely developed in measure, but complete in its humanity



RANJANA CHOPRA

of the nation's progress. This is the spirit that underlies Janjatiya Garima Utsav: a national celebration of a journey towards Viksit Bharat, where progress is not a privilege of geography or circumstance, but a right belonging equally to every citizen.

The scale of the ambition

To appreciate why technology has become indispensable to tribal development, one must first appreciate the magnitude of challenge. Pradhan Mantri Janjati Adivasi Nyaya Maha Abhiyan (PM-JANMAN), Dharti Aaba Janjatiya Gram Utkarsh Abhiyan (DAJGUA), the National Sickle Cell Anaemia Elimination Mission, and related initiatives cover more than 63,000 villages across 549 districts and 2,911 blocks in 30 States and Union Territories, benefiting more than 5.5 crore tribal citizens. With special focus on Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups (PVTGs), these efforts aim to ensure saturation coverage of essential services such as housing, drinking water, sanitation, education, healthcare, connectivity, and livelihoods. Reaching every family across such diverse and expansive terrain demands system that are data-driven, connected, and responsive and that is precisely what we are building.

Janjatiya Garima Utsav this year is organised around four thematic weeks, that together reflect the full arc of tribal development. The opening theme, "Technology as a Development Driver," captures how digital systems, science, and innovation are helping extend governance and opportunity to some of India's remotest communities. At the heart of this vision lies a simple principle: development must reach the last mile while remaining deeply respectful of tribal languages, cultures, heritage, and traditional knowledge systems.

Technology in service of tribal dignity

The most vivid illustration of what technology can accomplish when directed with purpose is BIRSA 101 — India's first indigenous CRISPR-based gene therapy for sickle cell disease. Sickle cell disease has long posed a significant health challenge for tribal populations, and India is now answering that challenge with advance science rooted in equity and accessibility. The Ministry of Tribal Affairs has extended financial assistance to support research, clinical trial infrastructure, and technology transfer in collaboration with the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR), CSIR-Institute of Genomics and Integrative Biology (IGIB), and Serum Institute of India Pvt. Ltd. A recent seminar at CSIR-IGIB brought together scientists, policymakers and Sickle cell warriors, reflecting both the scientific progress and the human urgency behind the efforts.

The shared goal is clear: to develop an affordable, one-time curative treatment that can reach every tribal family in need. BIRSA 101 is not merely a medical milestone. It is a declaration that India's most advanced science will serve its most deserving communities. This conviction runs deeper than a single initiative. Efforts such as the Traditional Knowledge Digital Library (TKDL) and Ayurgenomics demonstrate how modern technology can help document, validate, and preserve the rich medicinal and ecological knowledge long safeguarded by tribal communities. The same spirit of inclusion is shaping how artificial intelligence is being integrated into tribal development. At the India AI Impact Summit 2026, the Ministry presented range of AI-enabled platforms built on a simple but powerful belief: that language is not a barrier to be overcome but an identity to be celebrated. Adi Vaani, an AI-powered Translator for Tribal Languages, supports text-to-text and text-to-speech translation, OCR, and delivery of government scheme information in tribal languages, enabling citizens to engage with public services in the language



The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

TECHNOLOGY IS ALSO BECOMING A POWERFUL INSTRUMENT OF CULTURAL ASSERTION AND ECONOMIC EMPOWERMENT. THE FORTHCOMING TRIBEX PLATFORM AIMS TO CREATE A DIGITAL ECOSYSTEM FOR PROMOTING TRIBAL ARTS, LANGUAGES, TRADITIONAL KNOWLEDGE, MUSIC, CRAFTS, AND CULTURAL EXPERIENCES

The writer is Secretary, Ministry of Tribal Affairs

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they speak at home. TriBoT, a multilingual conversational AI assistant, further strengthens this effort by providing real-time guidance and grievance support to citizens in remote regions. These efforts were also discussed during a national seminar organised with the Bhagwan Birsa Munda Cell and IIT Delhi, which focused on culturally sensitive and community-centric applications of AI, including long-term preservation and strengthening of tribal languages.

Technology is also becoming a powerful instrument of cultural assertion and economic empowerment. The forthcoming TribeX platform aims to create a digital ecosystem for promoting tribal arts, languages, traditional knowledge, music, crafts, and cultural experiences. Complementing this effort, the proposed GI Potential Art and Craft Atlas of Tribal India will digitally map tribal handicrafts, forest products, and traditional art forms with Geographical Indication potential, helping strengthen branding, market access, and recognition of tribal intellectual heritage. Innovation Hubs, planned across Tribal Research Institutes in five states on a pilot basis, will go further still, combining design and product development support, GIS-based planning dashboards, and incubation infrastructure for innovation-led tribal entrepreneurs and startups.

Technology is equally transforming the way governance reaches tribal communities. Survey Setu, deployed under PM-JANMAN for PVTG household surveys, enables real-time, geo-tagged monitoring of welfare delivery across remote regions. Operating across 18 States and 1 Union Territory, the platform has already recorded 3.43 lakh household submissions with support of 8,552 surveyors. Such data-driven systems help ensure that every eligible family is identified and connected to essential services. In parallel, the Ministry is developing an AI-enabled Forest Rights Act governance platform to streamline claim submissions, GIS-based mapping, workflow monitoring, and grievance redressal. Together, these initiatives are making governance more transparent, responsive, and accessible for tribal citizens.

Tribal communities: Drivers of Viksit Bharat

There is a moment that, captures the essence of everything we are working towards. It is not found in a policy document or a ministerial review. It is found when a tribal woman in a remote habitation, empowered by technology, by language, and by the assurance that the state is listening, engages with government services on her own terms and receives an answer with full dignity. That moment is not the end of a journey. It is the beginning of a new chapter in India's national story. Janjatiya Garima Utsav carries this message with pride. Tribal communities, with their resilience, their ecological wisdom, their artistic traditions, and their deep roots in this land, are not waiting at the threshold of Viksit Bharat. They are among its most powerful and inspiring drivers.

As technology bridges distances, as science delivers healing, as AI speaks in the languages of the forests and the hills, and as governance reaches the last family in the farthest village, we move closer each day to India that is not merely developed in measure, but complete in its humanity. That is the Viksit Bharat we are building together, inspired by the vision of Prime Minister.

An energy crisis in disguise



ACHARYA PRASHANT

to drive less, take public transport, work from home where possible, delay foreign travel and refrain from buying gold, he made a request that was reasonable, practical and entirely correct. It was also, in a more fundamental sense, an indictment.

The problem runs in two directions. One is ignorance: the ordinary citizen has no idea what petrol consumption costs the country or the climate. The other is more uncomfortable: some of what needs to be known has been encountered and set aside because genuinely absorbing it would require a reckoning with one's own habits, which is harder than ignoring them. The first failure is educational. The second is a failure of intent.

India spent \$134.7 billion on crude oil alone in the financial year ending March 2026. With the Iran war having driven Brent crude above \$109 per barrel, CRISIL has projected the current account deficit to widen to 2.2 per cent of GDP in FY27. India's foreign exchange reserves have declined by \$40 billion since the Iran war began, and the rupee has lost 7 per cent of its value against the dollar in 2026, making it Asia's worst-performing major currency. India is simultaneously the world's second-largest importer of gold, spending a record \$72 billion in FY 2025-26 on what is primarily a consumption and status purchase.

The concentration of carbon dioxide in the atmosphere has risen from 280 parts per million before industrialisation to 430 today, with fossil fuel combustion responsible for 90 per cent of that change. Species are being driven to extinction by fossil fuel combustion at rates climate scientists classify as the sixth mass extinction in Earth's half-billion-year history, the first caused not by an asteroid or volcanic event but by the accumulated choices of one species acting upon unexamined desire. India's own carbon dioxide emissions grew by 4.6 per cent in 2024, the highest rate among major economies.

Rising income explains the capacity to consume. It does not explain the compulsion. These are different things, and conflating them produces recommendations that address the first while leaving the second entirely untouched.

The connection between fuel consumption and the absence of a genuine inner life is not metaphorical. It is a mechanical chain. The human being who believes satisfaction must be sought outward, because he has found no access to genuine sufficiency within, acts upon his emotions and desires without examining what drives them. Every desire acted upon requires energy. Energy, in a civilisation built on fossil fuels, means burning them. The citizen sitting in traffic in his third car is not simply making an economic choice. He is pursuing a fullness he has not found within and does not see what he is doing. The fuel is not the cost of getting somewhere. It is the cost of the attempt.

The dispersed centre, the ego that has no fixed point of sufficiency, has scattered its search across a hundred objects simultaneously. A vehicle here, a gold purchase there, a foreign holiday, an apartment upgrade, a new phone before the old one has worn out, a flight taken not for any destination but for the proof of having gone: none of these objects resolves the insufficiency; each merely displaces it briefly. The centre is not completed by any of them because it is not the absence of objects that has made it incomplete. It is incomplete by definition, constitutively, as the very structure of what it is to be an ego at all. The reaching does not end because the ego finds what it was reaching for. It ends only when the ego honestly sees what the reaching is and what it is not.

A population of people who cannot sit quietly with themselves will consume more than a population that can. This is not a moral judgement. It is a mechanical description of how inner poverty converts into outer demand. In the aggregate of 1.4 billion people, the inner condition of each person adds up to a macroeconomic profile and a carbon footprint. These are not separate domains. They are the same domain described in different units.

The citizen who cannot examine what actually drives his consumption cannot restrain it because he does not know what he would be restraining. He does not see that what he calls aspiration is the ego's perpetual dissatisfaction wearing the costume of legitimate ambition.

This is the second and more serious failure the appeal reveals: not merely the failure of information, but the failure of a society to honestly recognise what it has encountered and quietly set aside. People have encountered the information and chosen not to be changed by it because being changed by it would cost something. That cost is the only cost that actually matters. It is also the only one that a government appeal cannot assess or collect on anyone's behalf.

What the appeal could not say, because public discourse has not yet developed the vocabulary, is that the petrol problem and the gold problem and the current account problem and the carbon dioxide problem are not four separate failures but one: a vast population of egos running a structural deficit, reaching outward for what can only be found, if it can be found at all, in the other direction.

An economy that rests on this kind of demand carries a fragility that no foreign exchange reserve can fully buffer, no interest rate can adequately hedge and no government appeal, however sincere and urgent, can structurally address. The appeal was necessary. In a nation genuinely awake to itself, it would not have been. That gap is the real measure of the distance India has to travel, not in kilometres of pipeline or gigawatts of renewable capacity, but in the quality of what the citizen knows about himself and what no policy instrument, however well designed, can provide in his place.



Acharya Prashant is a philosopher and author whose work centres on self-inquiry and its application to contemporary life

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Sixteen deaths a day: Every dowry death shames entire Indian society



SIDDHARTH MISHRA

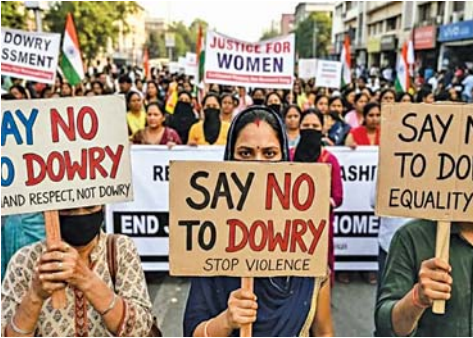
of continuity of dowry system, in India, in public discussion. Irrespective of the veracity of the causes of these deaths, it is so unfortunate, as we stand at a juncture of civilisational peak, that we still hear of dowry deaths that result from dowry related harassment. As per NCRB data, India recorded 5,737 dowry deaths in 2024, translating to about 16 women losing their lives every single day. Every conscientious citizen is naturally shaken to know this death ratio and is compelled to ask the question that why is it that the civilised society still has to hear of, and bear with, the dowry deaths?

At a point of time when India boasts of becoming a Vishva Guru and claims of being the fastest growing economy making all round development, how pernicious is it to have the phenomena of dowry death existing in this country. How farcical it is for a country to make such tall claims when it rather than ensuring respect and security, miserably fails to protect

its own daughters. Indian society very pompously boasts of empowerment, security and respect for women, and posits to be place where girls are worshipped and treated as deities. However, shamefully, we still have the retrograde practice of dowry prevailing among almost all the communities throughout the nook and corner of this country.

Though laws and machinery exist to prevent and control the menace of dowry in India, but that has largely remained ineffective in stopping or eradicating the social evil of dowry which continues and is widely pervasive in India. Indian laws such as the Dowry Prohibition Act, 1961 and the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023 contain necessary provisions to check the menace of Dowry. Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023 in its Section 80 (formerly Section 304B of the Indian Penal Code) applies specifically to cases of dowry death occurring within seven years of marriage while other provisions of law such as Section 85 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (formerly Section 498A IPC) continue to provide protection against cruelty and harassment for dowry demands irrespective of the duration of marriage. The Dowry Prohibition Act, 1961 prohibits and penalizes giving or taking of dowry so as to safeguard women against dowry harassment. Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023 provides for speedy investigation and trial of criminal cases including Dowry related cases.

The government has already directed that



the dowry related cases must be adjudicated expeditiously to avoid further harassment of the women and has even appointed the dowry prohibition officers, and keeps issuing advisories to all States/UTs from time to time to effectively deal with, and for proper enforcement of law and convictions in, women related crimes. Further, Bureau of Police Research & Development, conducts training programmes for personnel of criminal justice system including investigation officers, prosecution officers and medical officers etc. to deal with crime against women effectively and sensitively.

However, unfortunately, despite such comprehensive legal measures, the evil of dowry continues to exist in Indian society, and leads to frequent conflicts and disputes that sometime result in dowry deaths as well. This state of affairs signifies that the solution to this

problem cannot be provided merely by legal measures, rather the solution must be sought elsewhere as well. Thus, tackling this problem requires not only making strong laws and ensuring their effective implementation but also simultaneously educating and sensitising people against this evil practice.

The voices against dowry must emerge from within the society in the form of strong public opinion to fulfil the gap between law and public policy in this regard. Thus, there is pressing need to educate and sensitise the society about the ill effects of practicing the dowry system. The presence of dowry system is not in the interest of the society and it creates a distrust in the institution of marriage, the ill effects of which have already started appearing through delayed, broken or no marriages.

In this scenario, members of the civil society should come forward voluntarily and stop giving and taking dowry in marriages of their children. The families must educate their children, especially, their sons against the dowry system and encourage them to be self-dependant. Boys should be taught to have high self-esteem, who should consider taking dowry as an inferior and insulting practice. Men and women in the families across all the communities must become part of a mass campaign for giving up the bad practice of dowry. The government must run campaigns against giving and accepting dowry in any form in the marriages. Even civil society should run #QuitDowry campaign through social media

so that it turns into a mass movement and people, especially, the youth of this country start treating dowry as a degrading practice.

This movement shall succeed the day when dowry shall come to be treated as amounting to beggary and accepting it shall be considered as receiving alms. As the circumstances that led to the origin of dowry system do not any longer exist in this country, so there is no justification of its continuation at present. Dowry death is a curse for, and a darkest blot on, the whole civilised society as well as the state. It impinges upon the capacity of the state to protect the members of half of its population. Dowry death is not just a horrendous crime but also a matter of gravest concern and shame for the whole society.

However, if even a single dowry death does not shake the conscience of the society, then it severely reflects on the poor value system of members of society, and also adversely impinges on the values that the society is going to pass on to its future generations. The state and the society need to seriously start thinking about curbing this menace and should take meaningful, effective and foolproof measures to eradicate the social evil of dowry from the Indian society, completely.

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Three-day interim bail for Umar Khalid in UAPA case

The Delhi High Court on Friday granted three-day interim bail to activist Umar Khalid, who is in custody in a case under anti-terror law UAPA concerning the "larger conspiracy" behind the February 2020 riots in the city's northeastern parts.

A bench of Justices Prathiba M Singh and Madhu Jain permitted Khalid to be released from June 1 to June 3 to enable him to meet his mother who has to undergo a surgery. The bench noted that the Supreme Court rejected Khalid's regular bail plea on January 5 but granted him the reprieve by taking an "empathetic view."

"Taking an empathetic view, this court is inclined to grant him interim bail for three days from June 1 to June 3 to enable the appellant to spend time with his mother," the court concluded.

(PTI)

SC grants interim bail to two Delhi riots accused

The Supreme Court on Friday granted interim bail of six months to two Delhi riots accused while referring to a larger bench the question of law on whether prolonged incarceration and delay in trial can override the statutory restrictions on bail.

A bench of Justices Aravind Kumar and PB Varale refused to comment on the recent verdict given by a bench headed by Justice BV Nagarathna in which it criticised the January 5 verdict denying bail to activists Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam. The Delhi Police has sought reference of the question of law to a larger bench on whether prolonged incarceration and delay in trial can override the statutory restrictions on bail under anti-terror laws such as the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, 1967 (UAPA).

The bench justified the denial of bail to Khalid and Imam in the Delhi riots case, saying it was based on an accused-based evaluation, role ascribed to them and not that Article 21 was considered subordinate.

(PTI)

NCERT row: SC modifies earlier order concerning three academics

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday modified its March 11 order that had directed the Centre, states and others to disassociate from three academics, following a row over an NCERT book chapter containing "offending" contents on corruption in the judiciary.

The apex court left it open to the Centre, States, Union territories, public universities and institutions that receive funds from the Central or State Governments to take an independent decision on the issue, without being influenced by its observations made in the March 11 order.

A bench of Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi also recalled the part of the March 11 order that had recorded that the three academics — Professor



Michel Danino, Suparna Dwakar and Alok Prasanna Kumar — had "deliberately and knowingly misrepresented the facts" in order to project a negative image of the Indian judiciary to the students of Class 8.

The bench passed the order while hearing a plea moved by the three academics who explained their stand, saying no individual had the sole say in the drafting of the content and it was a collective process.

The court also observed that its comments were made in context of the contents and not the individuals.

On March 11, acting tough against the three experts involved in the drafting of the controversial chapter in the National Council of Educational Research and Training's (NCERT) social science book for Class 8, the court had directed the Centre and all states to disassociate from them.

Constitution not a privilege of few cosmopolitans, belongs to every citizen, says CJI Surya Kant

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Constitution belongs to all citizens equally and is not a privilege of a few cosmopolitans who can afford cost-bearing processes and engage the best of the brains, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant has said.

The comments from CJI came on Thursday in a speech at the launch of senior advocate Indira Jaising's memoir 'The Constitution Is My Home: Conversations on a Life in Law'.

The chief justice, who was invited as the chief guest, could not attend the event and sent a video clip extending his warm greetings for the book launch and expressed his regret for not being present due to an upcoming meeting of BRICS judges.

"The Constitution is truly our shared home. It belongs not to judges alone, nor to lawyers, State or public author-



ities. It belongs equally to every citizen, be it an urbanite or a ruralite, or the poorest of the poor, or the marginalised, who seek justice within its framework and place faith in its promises.

"The Constitution is not a privilege of a few cosmopolitans who can afford cost-bearing processes and engage the best of the brains to assert something which our Constitution never

intended to offer," Kant said.

He said the Constitution is not simply a legal text governing society from a distance but is also a constant presence.

"It accompanies us in courtrooms and chambers, in arguments and deliberations. But its reach extends far beyond formal legal spaces and its influence is ultimately measured in the lives of citizens and in the character of our democracy," he said.

Observing that constitutionalism is concerned with preserving coherence between authority and principle, the CJI said public institutions function best when power and responsibility are exercised in a spirit of balance, accountability, transparency and fidelity to foundational values.

"It is this continuing commitment that allows a democratic society to respond to changing circumstances while preserving the ethos and ideals that sustain it," he said.



A nation cannot prosper without a fair justice system



PRASHANT TEWARI

Judicial corruption is not merely a legal problem; it is a civilisational crisis. When citizens begin to believe that justice can be purchased, delayed, manipulated, or selectively delivered, the moral foundation of society starts collapsing. Courts are meant to be the last refuge of the powerless. If that refuge itself becomes compromised, insensitivity spreads across institutions and ordinary people lose faith not only in law but also in fairness, honesty, and democratic accountability.

India's judiciary has historically produced towering constitutional guardians, yet repeated allegations involving favoritism, opaque appointments, delayed disciplinary action, post-retirement inducements, and unexplained judicial conduct have intensified public anxiety. The concern today is not merely about individual misconduct; it is about the systemic opacity that shields accountability.

As Nani Palkhivala famously observed, "The judiciary is the last hope of the common man." When that hope weakens, cynicism enters public life. Citizens begin accepting corruption as normal, influential offenders become emboldened, and ethical behavior appears foolish in comparison to institutional manipulation. A corrupt judicial culture silently legitimises corruption elsewhere because society imitates what institutions tolerate.

One of the major areas under scrutiny is the collegium system of judicial appointments. Conceived to preserve judicial independence from political interference, the system gradually evolved into an opaque mechanism criticised even by former judges and constitutional scholars. The criticism is not against judicial independence itself, which remains essential, but against the absence of transparency and measurable accountability in appointments and transfers.

Former Justice Jasti Chelameswar openly questioned the opacity of the collegium system, arguing that decisions affecting the nation's highest courts cannot remain beyond public scrutiny. Critics argue that the present structure often functions through informal net-

works, closed-door consultations, and undisclosed criteria. The absence of publicly available reasoning for selections or rejections breeds suspicion of favoritism and institutional bias.

Transparency does not weaken judicial independence; rather, it strengthens legitimacy. In mature democracies, institutions survive not because they are beyond criticism, but because they are answerable to constitutional morality. When judges are perceived as unaccountable elites insulated from consequences, public anger naturally intensifies.

This is precisely why many legal experts now advocate extremely harsh anti-corruption mechanisms within the judiciary. Such measures are not meant to intimidate honest judges; they are intended to isolate and punish the dishonest minority whose conduct damages the credibility of the entire institution. Judicial corruption is uniquely dangerous because it corrupts the authority meant to punish all other corruption.

Dr BR Ambedkar had warned that however good a Constitution may be, it becomes ineffective if those implementing it are not good. His observation is profoundly relevant today. A dishonest police officer can damage investigations, a corrupt bureaucrat can delay governance, but a compromised judge can distort justice itself and destroy constitutional trust.

The impeachment process for judges in India is another area demanding urgent reform. At present, impeachment is so cumbersome and politically difficult that it has rarely resulted in meaningful accountability. The high threshold was originally designed to protect judicial independence from political vendetta. However, over time, it has also created near-immunity. Many allegations end in resignation, quiet retirement, or institutional silence instead of transparent adjudication.

Lawmakers must therefore seriously consider diluting procedural barriers for initiating judicial accountability proceedings while still protecting due process. This does not mean allowing political persecution of judges. It means creating credible, time-bound, independent oversight mechanisms capable of investigating misconduct swiftly and transparently. Fear of accountability is essential in every constitutional office. Absolute insulation from scrutiny breeds arrogance, and arrogance eventually



breeds corruption. The same principle applies to administrative staff within courts.

Corruption often flourishes not only at the judicial level but within clerical systems involving listings, file movement, certified copies, registry functioning, and procedural access.

For an ordinary litigant, exploitation frequently begins before a case even reaches a judge. The justice system cannot claim moral authority while everyday litigants continue facing procedural extortion and administrative opacity.

Technology offers perhaps the most powerful opportunity to restore public confidence. India's judicial system still functions with startling levels of manual dependency and procedural opacity despite being burdened with millions of pending cases. Digitisation alone is not enough; intelligent transparency is required.

Artificial intelligence-driven case allocation systems can reduce human manipulation in bench assignment. Blockchain-backed digital records can prevent tampering with files and orders. Mandatory live-streaming of constitutional and high-public-interest matters can improve public trust. Automated disclosure systems can publish judicial performance metrics, adjournment patterns, asset declarations, and timelines of reserved judgments. E-filing and digital tracking can minimise middlemen and registry-level corruption. Most importantly, technology can democratise access to justice. A villager should not have to depend upon brokers or influence networks merely to understand the status of a case. Transparent digital systems reduce discretion, and reduced discretion reduces opportunities for corruption.

Justice VR Krishna Iyer once remarked, "The robe of the judge

does not make him superhuman." Judges, like all public officials, must remain accountable to constitutional ethics. Respect for the judiciary cannot be demanded through secrecy; it must be earned through integrity and transparency.

India does not need weaker courts. It needs cleaner, more transparent, and technologically accountable courts. Judicial independence and judicial accountability are not enemies. They are complementary pillars of constitutional democracy. The common citizen will regain faith only when justice is not merely pronounced in courtrooms, but visibly practiced within the institution itself.

A nation survives not merely on the strength of its economy or military power, but on the faith its people place in the justice system. Yet corruption in India's judiciary has become an open secret. Policymakers must first acknowledge that a systemic problem exists; merely brushing it aside will only deepen public distrust and weaken democratic institutions. As Martin Luther King Jr. famously said, "Injustice anywhere is a threat to justice everywhere." The growing perception that justice can be delayed, manipulated, or denied has created serious concerns among ordinary citizens who look upon the judiciary as their final refuge.

The introduction of the Jan Lokpal framework by the NDA Government was seen by many as a significant step toward combating corruption within public institutions, including the judiciary. Recently, the Lokpal observed that allegations of corruption in High Courts and district courts could come under its investigative ambit. However, the Supreme Court expressed reservations, arguing that such oversight could interfere with judicial independence. While judicial freedom is essential in a democracy, account-

ability is equally indispensable. As Montesquieu observed, "There is no crueller tyranny than that which is perpetrated under the shield of law and in the name of justice." A judiciary insulated from scrutiny risks eroding the very confidence it seeks to protect.

The constitutional process of impeachment for corrupt judges is so cumbersome and politically difficult that it rarely acts as an effective deterrent. Consequently, the common citizen often feels helpless in the face of judicial misconduct. Governments of the day may seek a "committed judiciary" aligned with their political agenda, but this undermines the constitutional promise of free and fair justice. In such circumstances, the poor and marginalised are left wondering where they should go for justice. As BR Ambedkar warned, "Rights are protected not by law but by the social and moral conscience of society."

The primary duty of any Government is to safeguard national security, maintain internal order, ensure sound fiscal management, and deliver fair and equitable justice. All other responsibilities are secondary to these core obligations. Unfortunately, successive Governments in India have allocated less than 0.05 per cent of the national budget to the justice delivery system. This chronic neglect has contributed to enormous case backlogs, inadequate infrastructure, and the growth of parallel corrupt practices that benefit only a privileged few. In effect, the system alienates 99 per cent of its own meritorious legal fraternity while empowering a small elite class that controls institutional mechanisms.

A strong and transparent judicial system requires substantial investment in infrastructure, technology, training, and judicial manpower. The budgetary allocation for the law and justice sector should be treated with the same seriousness as sectors such as infrastructure, agriculture, rural development, or industry. Justice is not a luxury; it is the foundation upon which democracy rests. As William Ewart Gladstone rightly said, "Justice delayed is justice denied." Unless urgent reforms are undertaken with political will and institutional honesty, millions of ordinary citizens will continue to suffer in silence, waiting endlessly for the justice that the Constitution promises them.

The author is a social and political analyst

SC to hear plea against CBSE's three-language policy next week

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday said it will hear next week a plea challenging the new policy of CBSE which has made study of three languages, including at least two native Indian languages, compulsory for Class 9 students beginning July 1.

Senior advocate Mukul Rohatgi mentioned the matter before a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi.

"This is an urgent PIL. The petitioners are students, teachers and parents. They are challenging the new policy of the CBSE by which in the 9th standard, two more languages have been made compulsory," Rohatgi said.

Urging the top court to list



the matter for hearing on Monday, Rohatgi said, "It will create a chaos".

The CJI said next week will be a miscellaneous week and the matter would be listed.

According to a recent circular issued by the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE), the board has made the study of three languages, including at least two native Indian languages, compulsory for Class 9 students beginning

July 1. The move is part of the CBSE's alignment of its Scheme of Studies with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 and the National Curriculum Framework for School Education (NCF-SE) 2023.

"In order to adequately address the competencies envisaged at the Secondary Stage, these textbooks will be supplemented with one appropriate local or state literary material, selected by schools, such as short

stories, poems, or nonfiction works," the board said.

It added that detailed guidelines regarding the selection and pedagogical use of supplementary literary material would be issued by June 15.

According to the circular issued on May 15, students opting for a foreign language may do so only as the third language after studying two native Indian languages, or as an additional fourth language.

"With effect from July 1, 2026, for Class IX, the study of three languages (R1, R2, R3) shall be compulsory, with at least two languages being native Indian languages," the circular said.

The board said till the dedicated R3 textbooks are available, Class 9 students shall use the Class 6 R3 textbooks (2026-27 edition) of the chosen language.

HC seeks details of arms licences of Brij Bhushan Singh, Raja Bhaiya, 17 others

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj

Observing that display of arms publicly is harmful for social harmony, the Allahabad High Court has asked the Uttar Pradesh Government to furnish details of arms licences of 19 people in the state including politicians Brij Bhushan Singh, Raja Bhaiya and Dhananjay Singh.

In his order passed on Wednesday, Justice Vinod Dwakar said, "In the name of self-defence, weapons that become instruments of intimidation promote fear rather than genuine security. A society in which armed individuals assert dominance through visible force



Allahabad High Court

and threats does not become more free or peaceful, rather it erodes public trust."

"It is the prima facie view of this court that the public display of weapons may create an illusion of dominance, strength and protection, but it often disrupts social harmony and generates fear and insecurity among ordinary people.

Although the open carrying of guns is sometimes justified in the name of self-defence, weapons that become instruments of intimidation promote fear rather than genuine security," the court added.

Besides Raghuraj Pratap Singh alias Raja Bhaiya, Brij Bhushan Singh and Dhananjay Singh, the 16 other people whose details have been sought are Sushil Singh, Vineet Singh, Ajay Marhad, Sujit Singh Belwa, Upendra Singh Guddu, Pappu Bhaukali, Indradev Singh, Sunil Yadav, Farar Azeem, Badshah Singh, Sangram Singh, Sullu Singh, Chulbul Singh, Sunny Singh, Chhunu Singh and Dr Uday Bhan Singh.

HC pulls up WFI over decision to declare Vinesh Phogat ineligible



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Friday pulled up the Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) for its decision to declare celebrated grappler Vinesh Phogat "ineligible" from participation in domestic events and asked the Centre to constitute an expert panel to evaluate her.

A bench of Chief Justice DK Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia observed that the WFI's departure from the earlier practice of permitting the participation of reputed athletes "speaks volumes," and asked the Centre to ensure that Phogat, who is seeking her return from a maternity break, is allowed to participate in the upcoming Asian Games selection trials.

The bench emphasised that motherhood is celebrated in the country, and the federation should not act with "vengeance."

It asked the Centre to constitute an expert panel to evaluate Phogat after the Government counsel submitted that the framework provided by the Sports Authority of India permits relaxation of eligibility criteria in certain cases. "Ask the experts to evaluate her chances. Ensure that she participates," the court orally said, as it clarified it would take up the matter at 2:30 pm again to enable the Government counsel to come back with further details with respect to the constitution of the team of expert.

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NEW DELHI | SATURDAY | MAY 23, 2026

BUSINESS11

Forex kitty drops \$8 billion to \$688.894 billion

India's forex reserves dropped \$8.094 billion to \$688.894 billion during the week ended May 15, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) said on Friday.

The overall reserves had jumped by \$6.295 billion to \$696.988 billion during the week ended May 8.

The kitty had expanded to an all-time high of \$728.494 billion during the week ended February 27 this year before the onset of the Middle East conflict which led to several weeks of a drop as the rupee came under pressure and the RBI had to intervene in the forex market through dollar sales.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has also made multiple public appeals starting May 11 to countrymen to conserve forex by cutting down on foreign travel, limiting fuel use and refraining from gold buys for a year.

For the week ended May 15, foreign currency assets, a major component of the reserves, decreased by \$6.483 billion to \$545.904 billion, the central bank's data showed. Expressed in dollar terms, the foreign currency assets include effects of appreciation or depreciation of non-US units, such as the euro, pound, and yen, held in the foreign exchange reserves.

Value of gold reserves also declined \$1.536 billion to \$119.317 billion during the week, the RBI said.

The special drawing rights (SDRs) were down by \$49 million to \$18.824 billion, the apex bank said. (PTI)

Strike call: SBI asks customers to use payment alternatives

The country's largest lender SBI on Friday advised customers to use alternative mediums for transactions after a strike called by staff for early next week.

SBI has requested its over 52 crore customers to use automated teller machines, customer service points, and prefer online banking services like YONO and UPI by the lender.

The bank, which holds about a fifth of the share in the country's overall banking activities, said efforts are on to provide "essential services" in over 23,200 branches, as per a post on its handle on the micro-blogging platform 'X'. It said the All India State Bank of India Staff Federation has given a notice for a two-day strike starting May 25. "We sincerely regret any inconvenience caused," the post from SBI said.

The staff has threatened the strike to press for various demands, including the recruitment of adequate employees. If the strike materialises, it will affect SBI's banking operations nationwide for five days, as the fourth Saturday and Sunday fall before the strike date. Besides, there will be a holiday in many states on account of Eid al-Adha on May 27, a day after the proposed strike ends.

The staff demands also include recruitment of messengers and armed guards, a change of pension fund manager option to NPS Employees, as per an AISBISF statement.

The body also demanded that the bank stop outsourcing permanent jobs, as it creates a direct risk of data leaks, misuse, fraud, and identity theft, endangering customer trust and exposing the bank to severe reputational and legal consequences.

Another demand concerns the appointment of the workmen's employee director on the board. (PTI)

India blocks China's plea for panel on solar sector at WTO

India has blocked China's request to set up a dispute panel at the WTO in a case that Beijing has filed against New Delhi's support measures for the solar cells, modules, and information technology sectors, an official said.

Earlier this month, China made this request to the WTO's (World Trade Organization) dispute settlement body.

The request follows the failure of bilateral consultations on reaching a mutually-agreed solution on the dispute filed by China in December last year.

The Geneva-based official said that India has blocked the first request of China for the establishment of a panel.

China has alleged that India's tariff or import duty on certain technology products, and measures like the use of domestic products over imported goods, discriminate against Chinese goods.

Beijing, which is a major exporter of goods under these sectors, had claimed that these support measures and incentives infringe rules pertaining to the WTO's General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade 1994, Agreement on Subsidies and Countervailing Measures and Agreement on Trade-Related Investment Measures.

Refuting China's allegations, India has stated the measures are completely consistent with the WTO rules.

India also said it was ironic that, despite acknowledging the importance of a responsible and diversified supply chain, a country estimated to control over 80 per cent of the global solar module value chain still finds it necessary to take measures that hinder the legitimate growth of the industry in other countries.

The request was blocked at the Dispute Settlement Body (DSB) meeting on May 22 in Geneva. (PTI)

Import duty hike to hit India's gold demand by 10%

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

India's gold demand is expected to contract by 50-60 tonnes this calendar year, around 10 per cent lower than the previous year, following the import duty hike, according to the World Gold Council (WGC).

"Looking at 2026 as a whole, we estimate that combined jewellery and bar and coin demand could decline by around 50-60 tonnes, around 10 per cent lower than the previous year, due to the impact of the import duty hike," WGC said in its India gold market update.

The gold import duty was raised sharply from 6 per cent to 15 per cent, making it the single-largest increase

on record and fully reversing the duty cut of July 2024. The Prime Minister has also appealed to consumers to avoid buying gold for a year.

Other factors, such as the gold price, changes to income levels, inflation, or effects from the monsoon, would further influence annual demand, it added.

"Our econometric models suggest that changes in import duties tend to impact gold demand in both the short and long term, although the impact differs across jewellery and investment products such as bars and coins. Investment demand appears more sensitive to duty changes, while jewellery demand has shown greater resilience," said WGC.

WGC said jewellery con-

sumption is influenced more by prices and inflation, and import duties have less of an impact.

This is likely because jewellery purchases are often required, particularly for wed-

dings and social occasions, said WGC. Investment demand, on the other hand, is linked to income levels and import duties, with higher duties and restrictions tending to weigh on

Gold jewellery retail sales volume to decline 13-15% in FY27: Crisil

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

India's organised gold jewellery retail sector is likely to see a further 13-15 per cent year-on-year decline in sales volumes this fiscal, following an 8 per cent drop last year, amid elevated gold prices and the recent import duty hike, a report said on Friday.

However, the sector is poised to achieve a robust revenue growth of 20-25 per cent year-on-year, driven by higher realisations, Crisil Ratings said in a report.

Elevated gold prices will lead to increased inventory holding costs and higher bank borrowings, however, a growth in both revenues and cash accruals will offset higher reliance on debt, resulting in stable credit profiles, as per the report.

In FY26, India imported 720 tonnes of gold, leading to a foreign currency outflow of \$72 billion.

Amid sustained high gold prices and as a measure to

reduce the trade deficit and support the currency, the Government recently raised customs duty on gold to 15 per cent from 6 per cent, aiming to reduce demand and curb imports, which is expected to hit the sales volumes to the lowest level in a decade, excluding the Covid-impacted fiscal 2021.

Although the uptick in realisations will yield inventory gains for retailers, some of these gains may be passed on to customers as deeper discounts to incentive volume sales. Domestic gold prices

soared by 55 per cent last fiscal due to a rise in global prices amid geopolitical uncertainties, as well as a depreciating Indian rupee against the US dollar.

This has hurt affordability, prompting a shift towards lightweight, lower-carat gold jewellery (16-22 carat range) and studded jewellery.

Meanwhile, investment demand has gained traction over the past two fiscals, with jewellery sales plummeting 25 per cent and sales of gold bars and coins surging over 50 per cent.

Gold drops to ₹1.64 lakh/10g as Iran talks temper market anxiety

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Gold prices retreated by ₹600 to ₹1.64 lakh per 10 grams in the national capital on Friday as tentative progress in US-Iran negotiations reduced precious metals buying, though unresolved tensions around the Strait of Hormuz kept traders cautious.

Snapping a three-day winning streak, the yellow metal of 99.9 per cent purity depreciated by ₹600 to ₹1,64,900 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes), according to local marketmen.

Gold prices witnessed a slight decline on Friday. The recent fluctuations in the bullion market are largely influenced by ongoing geopolitical tensions, particularly concerning US-Iran relations, alongside the volatility of the Indian rupee and movements in crude oil prices, Gaurav Garg, Research Analyst at Lemonn

GOLD & SILVER		
10g = ₹1,64,900*		
	1kg = ₹2,71,000*	
		
Spot gold prices for 24-carat in Delhi for per 10 grams		
Silver prices are in national capital for per kg		
Source: All India Sarafa Association		
*Provisional		

Markets Desk, said. However, silver prices remained flat at ₹2,71,000 per kilogram in the bullion market.

In the international markets, spot gold fell marginally lower to \$4,522.32 per ounce, while silver slipped 1 per cent to \$75.87 per ounce.

"Spot gold trading lower to \$4522 per ounce on Friday as despite narrowing dif-

ferences between Iran and the US, nuclear and Hormuz control remain contentious issues," Praveen Singh, Head of Commodities at Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said.

Meanwhile, Washington has warned that shipping through the Strait of Hormuz should remain toll-free, keeping investors cautious despite signs of diplomatic progress between the US and Iran.

Rupee rises 63 paise to close at 95.73 against US dollar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The rupee rose for the second consecutive session on Friday to close at 95.73 (provisional) against the US dollar on softening of crude oil prices and supposed intervention by the Reserve Bank.

Forex traders said markets found some comfort after comments from US Secretary of State Marco Rubio hinted that diplomatic talks linked to the Iran situation were moving in a constructive direction.

Moreover, positive domestic equities and a decline in US treasury yields also supported the rupee.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 96.30 against the US dollar, then touched an intraday high of 95.30 and a low of 95.68 against the US dollar in intraday trade.

At the end of the trading session on Friday, the rupee was quoted at 95.73 (provisional), higher by 63 paise from its previous close.

On Thursday, the rupee rebounded 50 paise from its

Rupee vs Dollar	
₹	\$
₹ per US \$	
95.81	-17p
96.20	-39p
96.52	-32p
96.86	-34p
96.36	+50p
95.73*	+63p
May 2026	
(Inverted scale) KBK Infographics	

all-time closing low to settle at 96.36 against the US dollar.

"We expect the rupee to trade with a negative bias on uncertainty between US and Iran, which may pressurise the rupee. However, optimism over peace deal and softening of crude oil prices may support the rupee at lower levels.

"US Treasury yields are also easing, which may also support the domestic currency. USD-INR spot price is expected to trade in a range of 95.50 to 96.30," said Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst at Mirae Asset ShareKhan.

Honda to bring more than 10 new models in India by 2030

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Japanese automaker Honda plans to drive in over 10 new models, including electric vehicle and compact SUV by 2030 in India, one of the three key markets it has identified for its future growth plans, according to a senior company official.

Honda Cars India Ltd (HCIL) on Friday launched the new version of its popular hybrid sedan City with introductory prices starting at ₹11.99 lakh while also unveiling its premium SUV ZR-V in India.

It will launch its first full electric vehicle in the second half of the ongoing fiscal in the country, HCIL President and CEO Takashi Nakajima

Honda Cars India Marketing and Sales Vice-President Kunal Behl, President and CEO Takashi Nakajima, Director Marketing and Sales Yujiro Sugino, during the official India premiere and reveal of the new Honda ZR-V e:HEV and the launch of the updated Honda City at Aerocity in New Delhi

told reporters here. "Recently we announced that we will be launching new models under two categories, that is, under 4 metres and the midsize cat-

egory. Last time, in Japan, we mentioned ten (models) but currently, we are counting more than ten (models)," Nakajima said when asked how many new models

Honda planned to launch in India going forward by 2030. In the ongoing fiscal, HCIL plans a total of six launches, including the City hybrid and the ZR-V hybrid, he said adding the launch of new City and unveiling of ZR-V mark the beginning of HCIL's new phase of accelerated growth in the market.

"India is among the top three focus markets to realise Honda's future growth, which will be driven by a strong pipeline of new products and our efforts to achieve cost competitiveness," Nakajima said.

He further said, "This year is a landmark year for us with six strategic launches that will sharpen our competitive edge and reinforce our brand

position in the market." Honda Motor Co had last week announced that it would start introducing models tailored to the Indian market from 2028 and leverage on its two-wheeler business to upgrade customers to passenger vehicles as part of rebuilding of its automobile business and the future direction.

The company has positioned India along with North America and Japan as priority markets for its future growth strategy and decided to strategically allocate its resources to these markets.

From 2028, the company will begin introducing strategic models tailored to the Indian market in two vehicle categories — category for

vehicles under 4 meters in length and the mid-size category. When asked how much of the new models will be India-specific models, Nakajima said it will be a mix of both India-specific and fully imported global models, like the ZR-V SUV.

He said Honda is looking to participate in the two fastest growing segments, sub 4 metres and the midsize, in India with a variety of powertrains ranging from internal combustion engine (ICE), hybrids to battery electric vehicles.

Nakajima said with a clearer direction of a multi technology pathway policy seen in India, the company has decided to focus on the two segments.

FROM THE WORLD

SRILANKA

LKR falls

against dollar

The Government on Friday said the sharp fall of the Sri Lankan rupee(LKR) against the US dollar was caused due to the war in West Asia and not a reflection of its management of the local economy. Deputy Minister of Finance Anil Jayantha Fernando's comments came a day after the endorsement by the International Monetary Fund's (IMF) of the local economy and the government's expectation of over \$1200 million influx from international lenders by month end. Sri Lankan rupee closed at 329.00/331.00 to the US dollar in the spot market on Friday, after trading at 342.00/350.00 the previous day, local media reported. Fernando told reporters here that the conflict in West Asia had caused international cost escalations in case of gas, fertiliser, shipping and insurance in addition to oil prices.

UK

Indian-origin man jailed

An Indian-origin man is among five gang members jailed in the UK for a total of 84 years for their involvement in what the Metropolitan Police described as a large-scale drugs conspiracy. Jagjit Singh, a 30-year-old from Birmingham, was sentenced to 10 years and six months for his role within a major organised crime group responsible for importing and supplying Class A banned drugs worth millions of pounds into London.

Slight progress in Iran talks: Rubio

SAMY MAGDY/ SAM MEDNICK
■ Tel Aviv

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said on Friday there was "slight progress" during talks with Iran amid uncertainty as to whether a deal will be reached or war will resume.

He spoke days after US President Donald Trump said he was holding off on a military strike on Iran because "serious negotiations" were underway. Trump has been threatening for weeks that the ceasefire reached in mid-April could end if Iran does not make a deal, with shifting parameters for strike such an agreement. Rubio spoke ahead of a meeting of NATO foreign ministers in



A man gestures at a mosque that was damaged after an Israeli airstrike hit a Hezbollah paramedic centre southern Lebanon

Helsingborg, Sweden, where the military alliance is expected to discuss what role it could play in helping

police the Strait of Hormuz once the war is over. Rubio said he didn't want to exaggerate the progress,

saying there had been "a little bit of movement and that's good." He said the conversations were ongoing. Still, in recent weeks there have been repeated claims of progress, yet a deal has not been reached. Trump has repeatedly set deadlines for Tehran and then backed off. But he's also previously indicated he would hold off on military action to allow talks to continue — only to turn around and launch strikes. That's what happened at the war's outset, when he ordered strikes in late February shortly after indicating he would let talks play out.

He said he called off attacks this week on Iran at the request of allies in the West Asia, including the

leaders of Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates, who have been targeted by Iran and its allied militias. But Trump's decision to give the talks a chance sparked tension this week with Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu.

An official who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to speak to the media said Thursday that Trump and Netanyahu had a "dramatic" phone conversation on Tuesday about the status of the Iranian negotiations and that Israel is angry with Trump's efforts to strike a deal with Iran. Trump later told reporters that Netanyahu will "will do whatever I want him to do." (AP)

Munir leaves for Tehran amid US-Iran peace effort

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan Army Chief Field Marshal Asim Munir on Friday left for a crucial visit to Tehran amidst efforts to broker a peace deal between the US and Iran to end the war in the region, according to security sources.

His second visit to Tehran in little more than a month comes after progress was reported in talks held by Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi, who has been in Iran since Wednesday, with top Iranian leadership, including twice with Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, according to sources.

Field Marshal Munir will meet with important Iranian dignitaries and



discuss Iran-US talks, peace in the region and other important issues during his visit to Iran, they said.

Separately, Iran's state-run Press TV quoted the official IRNA news agency as saying that Field Marshal Munir is en route to Tehran to hold talks with

Iranian officials. His visit comes after Foreign Office spokesperson Tahir Andrabi, when asked about it, said he could "neither deny nor confirm" reports about a "high-level delegation" visiting Iran from Pakistan.

Andrabi earlier said that Rubio's statement was in reference to Naqvi's visit to Iran and not any other visit. He also said that Pakistani leadership was in touch with the Iranian President, adding that "this is part of engagements with neighbouring countries".

Munir dashed to Tehran after Interior Minister Naqvi held two rounds of talks with Iranian Foreign Minister Araghchi as part of efforts to end the conflict in the region.

Naqvi landed in Tehran on Wednesday on an unannounced visit, his second in less than a week, aiming to reduce the differences between Tehran and Washington.

He has already met the top Iranian leadership, including President Masoud Pezeshkian, Iran's interior minister, and other senior officials.

Foreign Minister Araghchi met Naqvi on Thursday and Friday to review proposals for resolving disputes, Iran's semi-official Tasnim News agency reported. Naqvi and Araghchi discussed detailed proposals aimed at ending the US-Iran conflict, Geo News reported, quoting Iran's official media. (PTI)

H-1B visa registrations drop 38.5% in FY 2027



SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

Registrations for H-1B visas dropped by 38.5 per cent in fiscal year 2027 with the US saying it had approved more applicants with advanced degrees and higher salaries of those "making a real impact on the economy."

The decision by the US Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) is likely to affect the Indians the most, who made up an estimated 71 per cent of all approved H-1B applications in recent years. In a post on X on Thursday, the USCIS said only 17.7 per cent of all selected registrations were in the lowest wage category.

"The number of properly submitted registrations plummeted by 38.5 per cent, from 3,43,981 in fiscal year 2026 to just 2,11,600 in fiscal year 2027," the USCIS said.

Nearly three-fourths of the applications approved were of persons holding masters degrees or higher, the USCIS said. "We're approving more applicants with advanced degrees and higher salaries — especially those who studied at US universities. An overwhelming 71.5 per cent of selected aliens hold a US master's degree or higher, compared to 57 per cent last year," it said.

It said these skilled workers are making a real impact on

the economy and the US was closing the door on the low-wage and low-skilled foreign labour pipeline approved under Biden administration policies. "This year, only 17.7 per cent of all selected registrations were in the lowest wage category," the USCIS said.

"This data is a clear sign that the days of abusing the programme with mass, low-wage registrations are over, and that the programme is better serving its intended purpose of attracting highly skilled foreign workers and protecting the wages, working conditions, and job opportunities of American workers," it said.

The USCIS said President Donald Trump's policies of placing America First were displaying results.

"These changes are all good, in the sense of being less bad — but only the real solution is to abolish the H-1B programme altogether (along with OPT, and more)," Mark Krikorian, Executive Director, Center for Immigration Studies, said in a post on X.

Indians make up an estimated 71 per cent of all approved H-1B applications in recent years, according to the USCIS data, with China in the second spot. The major fields include technology, engineering, medicine, and research. (PTI)

BSES

BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, New Delhi

TENDER NOTICE

Date: 23.05.2026

Sealed tenders under two parts (Un priced & priced) are invite for the supply of following materials from all bidders:-

NIT No.	Brief Item Description	Estimated Cost (₹)	Cost of EMD (₹)	Due Date & Time of Submission	Date & Time of Opening
CMC/BR/26-27/FK/CR/SS/1362	CIVIL WORKS FOR PROVIDING CABLE DUCT FOR LAYING 72 NOS. CABLES IN FRONT OF PULLMAN HOTEL AT IGI AIRPORT, DIAL – AEROCITY, NEW DELHI.	2.70 Crores	5.40 Lakhs	12.06.2026 15:00 HRS	12.06.2025 15:15 HRS
CMC/BR/26-27/FK/PR/SS/1363	SUPPLY OF 7561 NOS. 9MTRS (160KG) AND 3327 NOS. 11MTRS (365KG) PSC POLES.	6.35 Crores	6.35 Lakhs	05.06.2026 15:00 HRS	05.06.2026 15:30 HRS

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Telephone No. : +91 11 4910 7235 | Website : www.bsesdelhi.com

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is hereby inform^{ed} to the general public that Late Mrs. Sheel Virmani had executed a Will dated 11.12.2015 in favour of his legal heir Mrs. Sapna Bhardwaj, Mr. Aparna Vasisht & Mr. Rahul Virmani. regarding the property situated at Flat No. 0201, Second Floor, super area 2623 sq. ft., Block-03, Harmony, Sector-50, Gurgaon, Haryana. After the death of Mrs. Sheel Virmani the said property has been transferred in the name of Mrs. Sapna Bhardwaj, Mr. Aparna Vasisht & Mr. Rahul Virmani and Pursuant to the said Will and the Sale Deed regarding the aforesaid property is proposed to be executed by the said legal heir. If any person has any objection, claim, right, title, interest, dispute, lien, or demand regarding the above-mentioned property, he/she may contact the undersigned along with supporting documents within 7 days from the publication of this notice, failing which it shall be presumed that no objection exists and the transaction shall be treated as final and binding. please contact Advocate Bhupander Kumar, Ph no. 8295949981 # 1591, SECTOR 16-17, HISAR WITHIN 7 DAY OF THIS PUBLICATION.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mr. Ujjawal Taneja to inform the public at large that Mrs. Renu Bala is purchasing the Built Up Entire Top Floor with roof rights, of property NO."D-89 and D-81", measuring 72 sq. yds., khasra NO.304/212, 303/215, 308/221, situated at Ganesh Nagar, Pandav Nagar Complex, Village Shakarpur Khas, Illaga Shahdara, Delhi-110092 from Mrs. Swapna Behera who became the owner through Sale Deed Dated 06.03.2025 (Document No:2025/51/1946) executed by Mrs. Bulbul Pandey & Mr. Ashok Kumar Pandey. The said property will be financed and mortgaged by Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd., Noida. Therefore, to comply with the requirements of the BANK/NBFC, this public notice is issued. If any person has any type of claim, right, title, interest, or has created any mortgage over the said property, they are requested to inform in writing, along with their objections, at the address mentioned below within 15 days from today. Failing which, it shall be presumed that said property is free from all types of encumbrances, liens, etc. Lucern Legal LLP, B-83B, Second Floor, Opp. SBI Bank Sector 2, Noida UP-201301>Contact#0120-4269379

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Open E-TENDER NOTICE

For and on behalf of President of India. Sr. Divisional Mechanical Engineer (Chg.), Northern Railway, Delhi Division invites open e-tender on 'SINGLE PACKET' SYSTEM for following work from experienced and capable tenderers.

Supply & installation of F-Type mounting bracket stand locking arrangement for S-Trap gripping & protection as per ICF Drg. no.32963203 and Annexure-A, and SS cage/strainer in S-Trap (90-94 mm OD) as per Annexure-B of Railway Board L/No.2021/M(C)/141/2P/2 dated 08.05.2025 in LHB coaches over Delhi Division.

Work Place	Delhi Division (ANVT, DLI, DEE, NDLS, NZM)
Period of Work	Three (03) Months
Advertised Value	Rs.47.30,172.60/- (including provision of GST)
Earnest Money to be deposited	Rs.94,600.00/-, through net banking or gateway only
Tender Document Cost	Nil
Date and Time availability of E-Tender Document	From 21.05.2026 to 12.06.2026 at 12:00 hrs
Date and Time of E-Tender Closing	12.06.2026 12:00 hrs
Date and Time of E-Tender Opening	On 12.06.2026 after 12:00 hrs, if the date of opening happens to be holiday then E-Tender shall be opened on the next working day.
Place for opening E-Tender	Mechanical Department, Divisional Railway Manager's Office, Northern Railway, State Entry Road, New Delhi-55

Note: The complete particulars of the tender may be found in website www.reps.gov.in
No: NRDLIOMCNW912025RT Date: 22/05/2026 1733/2026
Serving Customers With A Smile

Noida

New Okhla Industrial Development Authority

Administrative Building, Sector-6, Noida, (U.P.)
Website : www.noidaauthorityonline.in

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tenders are invited from eligible contractors/firm for the following jobs against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on Noida Authority's official website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in & <https://etender.up.nic.in>. Please ensure to see these websites for any changes/amendments & corrigendum etc.

A) Fresh-Tender Work

Sl. No	JOB NO	NAME OF THE WORK	Tender Amount (Rs. Lacs.)
1	08/GM/SM (WC-1)/2026-27	D/o Village (Providing & Laying Concrete Pavement in Gali No.2 near Moonlight School near New Panchayat Ghar in Village-Nayabans), Noida.	52.22
2	09/GM/SM (WC-1)/2026-27	M/o Building (Annual Maintenance & repair work of Administrative Building in Sector-6), Noida.	40.36
3	11/GM/SM (WC-1)/2026-27	M/o Road (P/L Interlocking tile C and D-Block in Sector-7), Noida.	82.01
4	12/GM/SM (WC-1)/2026-27	D/o Village (R/o Plaster, Painting, Tile, Interlocking Tile etc. in Primary and Junior High School in Village Harola), Noida.	47.83
5	26/GM/SM (WC-1)/2026-27	M/o Drain (Re-construction of RCC drain in O & N Block & culvert in different location in Sector-12), Noida.	59.92

The above tenders can be uploaded from dated 25.05.2026 to 08.06.2026 up to 5.00 PM. Pre-qualification shall be opened/ downloaded on dated 09.06.2026 at 11.00 AM.

B) Re-Tender Work:

Sl. No	JOB NO	NAME OF THE WORK	Tender Amount (Rs. Lacs.)
6	01/GM/SM (WC-4)/ET/2026-27	Strengthening of Roads (P/L D.B.M. and B.C. on Internal road of Rajat Vihar Block A, B and C Sector-62), Noida.	77.55

The above tenders can be uploaded from dated 25.05.2026 to 01.06.2026 up to 5.00 PM. Pre-qualification shall be opened/ downloaded on dated 02.06.2026 at 11.00 AM.

General Manager (Civil)
Noida

CLEAN, GREEN, SAFE & SECURE NOIDA

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is for general information that I, MOHD IQBAL HUSSAIN S/O MOHD HADI HUSSAIN Residing at B-149, PLOT NO. 9, THIRD FLOOR, GALI NO. 5, NEAR CHAND MASJID, MANDAWALI FAZAL PUR, LAXMI NAGAR, EAST DELHI, DELHI-110092 declare that name of mine and my father have been wrongly written as MD EKBAL HUSAIN and MIR HADI HUSAIN in my all educational documents. The actual name of mine and my father are MOHD IQBAL HUSSAIN and MOHD HADI HUSSAIN respectively, which may be amended accordingly.

Public Notice

This is to inform the general public that Sh. Nirmal Singh is the possessor of Plot no. 83, area measuring 209.2 Sq. Yds, situated in the layout plan of The Narang Co-operative House Building Society Ltd., colony known as Narang Colony, Janakpuri, Delhi. Conveyance Deed Dated 09.02.1996 as Doc no. 2829 executed by POI through DDA in favour of Smt. Surinder Kaur in respect of said property. Thereafter, Regd. Will dated 05.07.2002 as Doc no. 1465 executed by Smt. Surinder Kaur in favour of Sh. Nirmal Singh in respect of said property. Unfortunately, Smt. Surinder Kaur had expired. Sh. Nirmal Singh intends to transfer the ownership of Second Floor without roof right "said floor", of above said property by way of Sale Deed to sh. Veritas North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301; Landline(s): +91012-04499711, e-mail: accounts@vnorth.in

Public Notice

This is to inform the general public that Mr. Pankaj Bansal had acquired the Property Bearing No. 18 & 19, area measuring 63 Sq. Yds., i.e., 52.67 Sq. Mtrs., out of Kharsa No. 1270/2 min, Situated in the residential Plot Jan Enclave, Village Loah Pargana & Tehsil Loni, District Ghaziabad, UP. Vide Notarized GPA, ATS & will dated 19.10.2022 executed by Mrs. Saroj in favour of Mr. Pankaj Bansal. Mr. Pankaj Bansal intends to transfer the ownership of above said property by way of Sale Deed to Mr. Rakesh Kumar, Mr. Pappu Prasad Gupta and Mrs. Meera Gupta are in the process of mortgaging the said property with SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding the transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-day period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client. If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-day period by contacting Lucern Legal LLP, North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301; Landline(s): +91012-04499711, e-mail: accounts@vnorth.in

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA

TENDER NOTICE

SR NO.	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	PWD B&R, AMBALA	CONSTRUCTION OF GOVT. VETERINARY HOSPITAL AT AMBALA CITY IN AMBALA DISTRICT. + 12 WORKS	19.05.2026 25.05.2026	118.11 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01712977224 pwd-eeep1-ambala@hry.nic.in
2	PWD B&R, GURUGRAM	RENOVATION OF 4 NOS. OFFICES AND WASHROOM, INCLUDING WALL PANELLING AND OTHER ANCILLARY WORK IN HUMAN RIGHT COMMISSION OFFICE AT PWD REST HOUSE AT GURUGRAM.	CLOSING DATE 28.05.2026	28.39 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01242322424 pwd-eeep1-gurgaon@hry.nic.in
3	PANCHAYATI RAJ, BHIWANI	PAVMENT OF 5 NOS KHET KHALIAN RASTA IPB (CM ANNOUNCEMENT 24219) AT VILLAGE- TIGRANA GP	20.05.2026 27.05.2026	143.31 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01664243927 preveeng.bhw@hry.nic.in
4	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, BHIWANI	REWINDING OF 10 NO. 150 HP MOTORS OF SIWANI CANAL IN SIWANI WATER SERVICES MECHANICAL SUB DIVISION TOSHAM.	CLOSING DATE 01.06.2026	8.09 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9812364411 xenmechbihwani@gmail.com
5	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, SIRSA	REPAIR THE DAMAGED PATCH LINING OF LOHGAIRH LINK CHANNEL FROM RD. 0 TO 13950 TAIL + 3 WORKS	CLOSING DATE 01.06.2026	11.48 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01666235426 xenorrsrs@rediffmail.com
6	AGRICULTURE & FARMERS WELFARE, ROHTAK	RECLAMATION OF WATERLOGGED LAND AND SALINE SOIL THROUGH VERTICAL DRAINAGE TECHNOLOGY PROJECTS IN THE VILLAGES LAHLI,MARODHI JATTAN,MARODHI RANGDAN(BLOCK-KALANAUR)	20.05.2026 01.06.2026	456.35 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9466723261 asco.rtk2015@gmail.com
7	AGRICULTURE & FARMERS WELFARE, ROHTAK	RECLAMATION OF WATERLOGGED LAND AND SALINE SOIL THROUGH VERTICAL DRAINAGE PROJECTS IN THE VILLAGES PATWAPUR,BALAB-II ,KAKRANA, GARHI BALAB AND ANWAL(BLOCK-KALANAUR) DISTRICT-ROHTAK	20.05.2026 01.06.2026	627.23 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9466723261 asco.rtk2015@gmail.com
8	AGRICULTURE & FARMERS WELFARE, ROHTAK	RECLAMATION OF WATERLOGGED LAND AND SALINE SOIL THROUGH VERTICAL DRAINAGE TECHNOLOGY IN VILLAGE MAKROULI KHURD,MAKROULI KALAN,RURKI (BLOCK-ROHTAK)AND BHARAN(BLOCK-MEHAM, DISTRICT-ROHTAK	20.05.2026 01.06.2026	821.92 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9466723261 asco.rtk2015@gmail.com
9	AGRICULTURE & FARMERS WELFARE, ROHTAK	RECLAMATION OF WATERLOGGED LAND AND SALINE SOIL THROUGH VERTICAL DRAINAGE TECHNOLOGY PROJECTS IN THE VILLAGE MADINA KORSAN AND MADINA GINDHRAN, BLOCK-MEHAM, DISTRICT-ROHTAK	20.05.2026 01.06.2026	815.30 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9466723261 asco.rtk2015@gmail.com
10	AGRICULTURE & FARMERS WELFARE, ROHTAK	RECLAMATION OF WATERLOGGED LAND AND SALINE SOIL THROUGH VERTICAL DRAINAGE PROJECT IN THE VILLAGES- BEHLA AND KHARKARA, BLOCK-MEHAM, DISTRICT- ROHTAK	20.05.2026 01.06.2026	763.61 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9466723261 asco.rtk2015@gmail.com
11	AGRICULTURE & FARMERS WELFARE, ROHTAK	RECLAMATION OF WATERLOGGED AND SALINE SOIL THROUGH VERTICAL DRAINAGE TECHNOLOGY PROJECT IN THE VILLAGE- RITOLI,PAHRAWAR,SAMARGOPALPUR KALAN ,SAMARGOPALPUR KHURD,NIDANA BLOCK AND DISTRICT-ROHTAK	20.05.2026 01.06.2026	684.15 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9466723261 asco.rtk2015@gmail.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT www.etenders.hry.nic.in

RO 45523-I-27-7

STATE BANK OF INDIA

E-AUCTION
SALE NOTICE

Home Loan Centre (HLC) C-59 Community Centre, Naraina Industrial Area Phase - 1, New Delhi-110028

NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION SALE ON 30.06.2026 FOR MOVABLE ASSETS

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Movable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8 (f) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.
 Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described movable property hypothecated / charged to the Secured Creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer State Bank of India, the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is Where is", As is What is" and Whatever there is" on 30.06.2026, for recovery of bank due to the secured creditor as under :-

Interested bidder may deposit Pre-Bid EMD with BAANKNET before the close of e-Auction. Credit of Pre-Bid EMD shall be given to the bidder only after receipt of payment in BAANKNET's Bank Account and up-dation of such information in the e-auction website. This may take some time as per banking process and hence bidders, in their own interest, are advised to submit the pre-bid EMD amount well in advance to avoid any last minute problem.

Date / Time of E-Auction on 30.06.2026 for 6 Hours from 20:00 AM to 04:00 PM with unlimited extn. of 10 minute each.

S. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)	Outstanding Dues for Recovery of which Property/ies is/are being Sold	Vehicle Description	Reserve Price (Rs.) (below which property could not be sold) Earnest Money (EMD) 10% of the Reserve Price Bid Increment Amount	Name of the Authorised (Signatory)
1.	Mr. Dharambir (Deceased) <u>Auto Loan A/c.:</u> 42218087609	Rs. 7,03,138/- as on 21.05.2026 plus Interest and other incidental Charges etc. thereafter	Make & Model: MARUTI VALENO ZETA CNG Regn. No.: DL10CX9982 Engine No.: K12NP4312558 Chassis No.: MBHHW13SPH524644 Date of Regn.: 01.09.2023 Odometer: 32308 Kms Fuel: Petrol / CNG (Grandeur grey)	₹ 6,03,000.00 ₹ 60,300.00 ₹ 1,000.00 *GST as applicable	Mr. Anil Kumar Chaudhary (Chief Manager) HLC, Naraina, New Delhi Mr. Amit Kumar Mob: 9205101634
2.	Mr. Rohit Gupta <u>Auto Loan A/c.:</u> 42902384058	Rs. 3,72,803/- as on 21.05.2026 plus Interest and other incidental Charges etc. thereafter	Make & Model: TATA TIAGO XE 1.2 RTN BS6 PH2 Regn. No.: DL10CX4785 Engine No.: REVTRN19BVXK21312 Chassis No.: MAT626367RKB13755 Date of Regn.: 20.04.2024 Odometer: 19281 Kms Fuel: Petrol (Daytona Grey)	₹ 3,06,000.00 ₹ 30,600.00 ₹ 1,000.00 *GST as applicable	Mr. Anil Kumar Chaudhary (Chief Manager) HLC, Naraina, New Delhi Mr. Amit Kumar Mob: 9205101634
3.	Mr. Tarun Aggarwal S/o Harish Aggarwal And Mrs. Lalita Aggarwal W/o Harish Aggarwal <u>Auto Loan A/c.:</u> 44019482930	Rs. 14,61,002/- as on 21.05.2026 plus Interest and other incidental Charges etc. thereafter	Make & Model: SKODA AUTO VOLKSWAGEN SLAVIA SPORTLINE 1.0 TSI AT Regn. No.: DL10CZ6497 Engine No.: DZW053666 Chassis No.: MEXBPCBPB5SG014331 Date of Regn.: 28.04.2025 Odometer: 18750 Kms Fuel: Petrol (Deep Black Pearl)	₹ 10,62,000.00 ₹ 1,06,200.00 ₹ 1,000.00 *GST as applicable	Mr. Anil Kumar Chaudhary (Chief Manager) HLC, Naraina, New Delhi Mr. Amit Kumar Mob: 9205101634

Last Date and Time within which EMD to be remitted : 29.06.2026 before 23:59 Hrs. Bank account in which EMD to be remitted: 4897932507926. Account/ Wallet in which EMD to be remitted : Bidder's own wallet Registered with [BAANKNET](https://baanknet.com) on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT/RETS. EMD of Reserve Price to be transferred by bidders by means of challan generated on his/her/their bidder account maintained with [BAANKNET](https://baanknet.com) on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT from his/her/their bank. For any assistance, please call please call [BAANKNET HELPPESK: +91 829120220](tel:91829120220), support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com and/or Authorized Officer.

TERMS AND CONDITIONS OF THE E-AUCTION ARE AS UNDER:

- (1) E-Auction is being held on "As is where is", "as is what is basis" and "whatever there is basis" and will be conducted "On Line" on 30.06.2026 from 10:00 AM to 16:00 Hrs. at <https://baanknet.com>. The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider [BAANKNET](https://baanknet.com) at their web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing>
- (2) Bank shall reserve the right to cancel/postpone the auction.
- (3) The Vehicle are available for inspection during banking hours on 29.06.2026 From 10:00 AM to 04:00 PM., **Contact Person - Mr. Amit Kumar, Mobile No.: 9205101634 (Resolution Agent).**
- (4) *** Successful bidder to pay GST as applicable on the successful bid amount, viz sale value.**
- (5) To the best of knowledge and information of the Authorized Officer there is no encumbrance on the property/ies. However the intending bidder should make their own independent inquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of the property/ies put on auction and claims/tihs/dues/affecting the property prior to submitting their bid.
The e-Auction Advertisement does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation of the Bank. The property is being sold with all the existing and future encumbrances whether known or unknown to the bank. The Authorized Officer shall not be responsible in any way for any third party claims/rights/ dues.
- (6) The Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of the successful bidder shall be retained towards part sale consideration and the EMD of the unsuccessful bidders shall be refunded. The Earnest Money Deposit shall not bear any Interest. The successful bidder shall have to deposit 25% of the sale price, immediately on acceptance of bid price by the Authorized Officer and the balance of the sale price on or before 15th day of the sale. Default in deposit of amount by the successful bidder would entail forfeiture of the whole money already deposited and property shall be put to the e-auction and the defaulting bidder shall have no claim/right in respect of property / amount.
- (7) For detailed terms and conditions of the sale please refer to the link at the Bank's Service Provider's web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> & e-auction website: <https://BAANKNET.com>

Date: 22.05.2026 Place: New Delhi
Authorized Officer, State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre, Naraina, New Delhi

PROSPECT

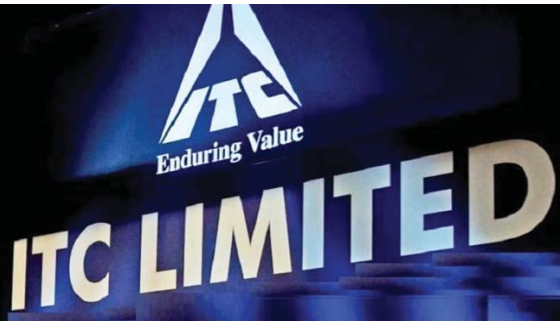
Customers prioritise reliable deliveries over speed: APAC study



India's ecommerce and quick commerce sectors have spent billions chasing speed. New research suggests they may have been solving the wrong problem all along.

According to the Eye on the Last Mile 6.0 APAC report, unveiled on May 21, 2026 at Last Mile Leaders Asia in Bangkok, when operators across the Asia-Pacific region were asked to name the single customer promise that matters most, predictable delivery time was the clear winner – chosen by 41 per cent of respondents. Fastest possible delivery trailed at just 22 per cent. Real-time tracking visibility, a capability the industry has spent a decade marketing and building, was chosen by a mere 10 per cent. The report was produced by FarEye in partnership with ASCLA and SCMAP. Speaking at the event, Kushal Nahata, Co-founder and CEO of FarEye said, "The next frontier is not speed – it is reliability, intelligence, and cost clarity. Operators who crack that convergence first will define the category. India has every reason to lead." The implication for India – where 10-minute and 20-minute delivery has attracted billions in investment and dominated logistics headlines for three years – is pointed: the capital flowing into speed infrastructure may be partially misdirected. Reliability, not velocity, is what customers are actually paying for.

ITC Ltd strengthens coastal ecology through mangrove conservation



As the world marks International Day for Biological Diversity, under the theme 'Acting Locally for Global Impact', ITC's large-scale and integrated biodiversity conservation initiatives demonstrate how grassroots action can deliver impactful ecological outcomes, build climate resilience and support livelihoods creation.

ITC has integrated biodiversity conservation within its large-scale sustainability programme spanning water stewardship, forestry and climate-smart agriculture, among others. ITC's biodiversity programme in collaboration with State Governments cumulatively covers nearly 7.8 lakh acres across 10 states in India till date and the aim is to cover 1 million acres under the initiative by 2030, as a part of its Sustainability 2.0 agenda.

As part of its integrated biodiversity conservation programme, ITC spearheaded a unique initiative in Andhra Pradesh that spans mangrove restoration and sea turtle hatchling conservation, demonstrating the impact of community-led ecological interventions. India's coastal ecosystems are increasingly vulnerable to climate change consequences such as cyclones, sea level rise, saline intrusion and coastal flooding.

Hearing in RIL-Centre gas dispute continues in SC

RANJIT KUMAR SINHA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday continued its high-stakes final hearing in the multi-billion-dollar Krishna-Godavari (KG) Basin gas dispute between the Central Government and a Reliance Industries Ltd (RIL)-led consortium of domestic and international energy firms.

The apex court is currently hearing the ₹12,800 crore (\$1.55 billion) appeal filed by RIL and its partners, challenging a February 2025 Delhi High Court Division Bench order.

The High Court's ruling had set aside a 2018 international arbitral award and a subsequent single-judge decision that originally cleared the consortium of any wrongdoing.

The consortium on Friday took forward its arguments

before a three-judge bench, led by Chief Justice Surya Kant along with Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M. Pancholi, insisting that they operated strictly within their licensed geographical limits under a valid Production Sharing Contract (PSC), meaning any incidental migration of gas cannot legally be classified as unjust enrichment.

Earlier in the week, the consortium informed the Supreme Court that it intended to approach the Union Government to resolve the long-standing matter out-of-court through conciliation or mediation.

However, the Bench refused to pause the active court proceedings while outside settlement talks took place.

The top court had made it clear that while doors for peace talks are open, the



court will not stop its clock.

The legal battle stems from the Union Government taking a hard line in court, fiercely alleging that the RIL-led consortium "virtually committed a theft" of natural gas that naturally flowed underground from state-owned ONGC's blocks into Reliance's adjoining KG-D6 area between 2009 and 2013.

Senior Advocate Kapil Sibal, representing the con-

sortium's foreign partners – UK energy giant BP Exploration (Alpha) and Canada's Niko Resources – on Friday submitted that the government's aggressive stance threatens to harm global investor trust and halt India's economic momentum.

Sibal reminded the bench that India deliberately allows 100% Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) in deep-sea

oil and gas sectors because these projects require massive capital and carry immense risks.

He argued that if stable international arbitration rulings can be easily overturned by local courts using retroactive laws, foreign companies will think twice before investing in India, ultimately slowing down national economic growth.

He asked what would happen if the situation were reversed – if ONGC had started pumping gas first, causing Reliance's gas to flow into the state-owned field. "Would the government act the same way and force ONGC to pay a private company?" he questioned, pointing out the unfair asymmetry in the government's logic.

Fiercely countering the government's "theft" narrative, Senior Advocate

Abhishek Manu Singhvi, appearing for RIL, had relied on basic physics to explain that natural gas is a "fugitive mineral." It does not sit still like solid coal; it moves naturally through underground rocks based on pressure differences, much like water absorbing into a sponge.

Singhvi had pointed out that ONGC was "sleeping over" its gas fields for 10 years without drilling or drawing gas. Because Reliance was actively working its own block, a natural pressure vacuum was created, drawing the neighbouring gas toward it.

A key technical argument raised by RIL is that the Delhi High Court (in its February 2025 ruling) wrongly treated the matter as a domestic dispute, ignoring the international nature of the consortium which includes foreign partners BP and Niko.

ITBP's first all-women expedition successfully summits Mt Everest



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Indo-Tibetan Border Police Force (ITBP) has successfully completed its first-ever all-women international mountaineering expedition to Mt Everest (8,848 m), marking a historic milestone in the force's mountaineering legacy.

The expedition, flagged off from Force Headquarters, New Delhi, on April 19, 2026, was undertaken in line with the vision of the Union Home Minister to conduct exclusive ITBP Everest expeditions for three consecutive years.

The 14-member team,

comprising 11 women climbers and 3 technical/support members, successfully summited Mt Everest on May 21, 2026, with the first summit at 0652 hrs via the South Col Route from the Nepal side.

The climbers displayed exceptional courage, endurance and teamwork while negotiating extreme weather conditions, low oxygen levels and difficult ice-wall sections in the "Death Zone" above 8,000 metres.

The expedition reflects the ITBP's commitment towards women empowerment, adventure leadership and

excellence in high-altitude operations.

As part of the Force's "Clean Himalaya – Save Glacier" campaign, the team also carried out environmental awareness activities and collected non-biodegradable waste in the Everest region.

With this achievement, ITBP has now successfully conducted 232 mountaineering expeditions, including five successful Mt Everest summits. The Force has also scaled six of the world's fourteen 8,000-metre peaks – Mt Everest, Mt Kanchenjunga, Mt Makalu, Mt Lhotse, Mt Dhaulagiri and Mt Manaslu.

VIT-AP University hosts grand 9th University Day ceremony

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

VIT-AP University celebrated its 9th University Day with great enthusiasm and grandeur on Thursday at its Amaravati campus, marking another significant milestone in the institution's journey of academic excellence, innovation, and social commitment.



The event was graced by Prasath P, Director - Head of Campus Relations, HCLTech, Chennai, Tamil Nadu, who attended the celebration as the guest of honour.

One of the major highlights of the event was the signing of a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) between CID, AP Police and VIT-AP University. The MoU was formally exchanged between Dr Ravi Shankar Ayyanar, IPS, DGP-CID, and Dr Arulmozhiharman, Vice-Chancellor of VIT-AP University, in the presence of Dr G. Viswanathan, Chancellor, VIT University, Chennai, appreciated the university's contribution to higher education and innovation, stating, "VIT-AP University is playing a significant role in nurturing future-ready talent and promoting socially driven impactful innovations. The institution's efforts towards

President and Managing Trustee of Buimerc India Foundation.

As part of the celebrations, the university honoured outstanding achievements across various categories through: Best Outgoing Students Award, Student Merit Awards -2026, Faculty and Staff Excellence Awards, Best Clubs and Chapters Awards, Sports Excellence Achievement Awards, Special Recognition Award - Student.

Speaking on the occasion, Prasath P, Director – Head of Campus Relations, HCLTech, Chennai, appreciated the university's contribution to higher education and innovation, stating, "VIT-AP University is playing a significant role in nurturing future-ready talent and promoting socially driven impactful innovations. The institution's efforts towards

research, entrepreneurship, and community service are truly commendable." He highlighted the importance of industry-academia collaboration and said, "Institutions like VIT-AP University are creating an ecosystem that bridges academic learning with industry expectations. Students graduating from such environments are well-prepared for the evolving global workforce."

Dr G. Viswanathan, Chancellor, VIT University, congratulated the award recipients and reflected on the university's vision, saying, "The 9th University Day is a celebration of dedication, perseverance, and collective achievement. We remain committed to providing world-class education while fostering innovation, leadership, and societal responsibility among students."

DAILY SUDOKU

3	2	9						
	7				3		2	1
					5	6	7	
	5	1	6					
	4	3				8	6	
					7	1	5	
	6	7	2					
9	8		7				3	
					7	9	5	

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

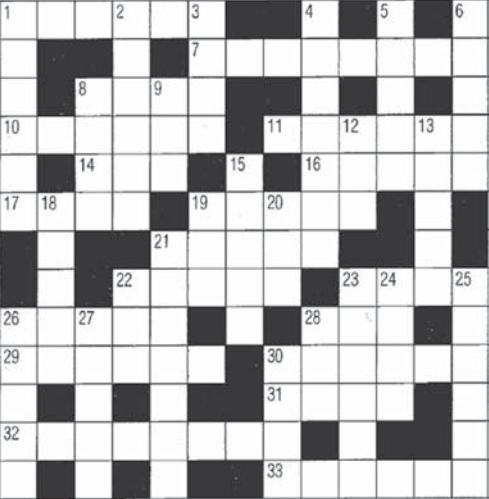
Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (22.5.26)

9	6	7	4	1	5	3	2	8
5	8	1	3	2	6	7	9	4
4	2	3	8	7	9	1	6	5
6	1	5	7	8	2	4	3	9
3	9	2	6	4	1	8	5	7
8	7	4	9	5	3	6	1	2
2	4	6	1	9	8	5	7	3
7	3	9	5	6	4	2	8	1
1	5	8	2	3	7	9	4	6

DOUBLE CROSSWORD SATURDAY | MAY 23, 2026



ACROSS

- Painter, French, noted for using black (6)
- Flighty fellow Aaron ought to emulate? (8)
- Hair treatment to interest the pools fan (4)
- Arrive when the entertainment's finished (4,2)
- Asked to offer a room (6)
- Took the rest of the day (3)
- Mechanical bird? (5)
- It's said to be due to the tea service (4)
- The present for a shifty toady (5)
- All upset about Oscar meeting a sticky end, it's true (5)

DOWN

- Being annoyed, rode us ragged! (6)
- Unique system that seems nothing new on some days (3,3)
- In more ways than one, it's not on the level (4)
- To close down, I see, in a fuel industry, has its point (7)
- Giant animal? (5)
- In Euston, especially, is it a gem? (5)
- Stop changing one's job (4)
- Though monotonous, it's arguably groovy (3)
- Thirsty doctor at the eye centre (3)
- Some patent errors to put in a book (5)
- Played to the grand finale (5)
- He's relatively willing to lend you

- Subdued by a cowboy? (5)
- Being caught outright, is tough (4)
- Admit everybody to the town centre (5)
- Not the complete CID man (3)
- He has a job to start the game! (6)
- Amount of wine in a vessel or little basket (6)
- Leer at a rounded leg, perhaps (4)
- Consumes six deliveries of food? (8)
- Test taken by a swimmer around the end of May (3-3)

- money (5)
- Help someone get to central Edgware (3)
- One brought up to be unchangingly paternal? (3)
- Somehow the old were let down (7)
- Little bed, as in Scotland (3)
- Its being on the river hardly needs mention (6)
- Trouble making a current piece of news (4)
- Hate finishing last on a shaky steed (6)
- Though superior, his boat was wrecked around Beachy Head (5)
- After swilling a lot of claret (5)
- May be of love or war (3)
- Send a piece of fencing (4)

Gurugram: Central Bank of India organises mega retail outreach programme

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

The Central Bank of India organises a nationwide mega retail outreach programme in Gurugram. The programme was graced by the august presence of Rahul Saxena, RH Gurugram.

The event witnessed enthusiastic participation from a large number of prospective borrowers and builders' representatives.

The outreach programme served as an effective platform to strengthen engagement with the retail sector.

Officials from the bank provided detailed insights into various retail schemes, along with initiatives undertaken by both the government and the bank to

promote and empower this sector. Officials highlighted the upcoming schemes and strategic initiatives of the bank aimed at accelerating retail growth.

A major highlight of the event was the on-the-spot sanctioning of loans & lead generation worth ₹101 crore, reaffirming the bank's strong commitment to supporting educational institutions, builders for real estate growth & the housing sector. The event concluded with a vote of thanks by Subhash Yadav, senior official of the Manesar branch, who expressed gratitude to all participants and stakeholders for their valuable presence and contribution to the success of the programme.



E-Tender Notice

GURU NANAK DEV UNIVERSITY, AMRITSAR

SHORT TERM E-TENDER NOTICE

Short Term E-Tenders are invited for the purchase of Computerized Bursting Strength Test, Digital Martindale Abrasion tester, MBTL Light Fastness Tester, Computerised Embroidery Machine Multicolor Single Head for T-shirts, Computerised Embroidery Machine Multicolor Single Head for Ladies' Suits, Embroidery Design Software (5 User) and GPU Computers be submitted online latest by 6/06/2026 upto 4:00 p.m. Detailed information can be obtained from website www.eproc.punjab.gov.in. Any corrigendum/Addendum related to these e-tender will be uploaded, if required, on Punjab Govt. website: eproc.punjab.gov.in

Director of Research

2426/12/2026-27/11642 Dated CHD :- 22/05/2026

Crochet's comeback can create jobs, strengthen India's economy: Giriraj



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Crochet and hand knitting are making a strong comeback in India, driven by Gen Z creators, slow-fashion trends and growing demand for handmade products. Union Textiles Minister Giriraj Singh said the revival of these traditional crafts has the potential to generate large-scale employment, empower women artisans and strengthen India's creative economy.

The minister was speaking at the unveiling of the 'Premium Hand Knitting Yarns Collection 2026' by Ganga Acrowools Limited at Le Méridien New Delhi. Organised in collaboration with Heartbeats Premium Yarns, the event brought together distributors, retailers, designers, entrepreneurs, self-help groups and artisan communities.

The exhibition highlighted how knitting and crochet are expanding beyond tradition-

al winter wear into home décor, boutique fashion, gifting and designer collaborations. A major attraction was the display of advanced "intelligent yarns" capable of creating self-forming patterns, textures and colour designs, making high-end craftwork easier and more accessible for creators.

Amit Thapar, President of Ganga Acrowools, said the company aims to build an ecosystem supporting creators, retailers and self-help groups. The company currently exports to more than 60 countries and manufactures over 900 yarn varieties.

Ganga Acrowools also announced a ₹750 crore manufacturing expansion in Punjab, aimed at boosting production, innovation and employment generation. The company said its "Knitting Happiness" initiative is focused on artisan partnerships and SHG-linked livelihood programmes to scale India's growing handmade craft economy.

BRIEFLY

Eriksen and Wolfsburg near relegation after 0-0 playoff draw



Christian Eriksen is one game away from Bundesliga relegation with Wolfsburg after a scoreless draw with second-division Paderborn in the first leg of their playoff on Thursday. Eriksen, who signed a two-year deal when he joined Wolfsburg in September, likely didn't imagine he'd find himself on the verge of demotion to Germany's second division at the end of his first season.

But if Paderborn wins the second leg of their promotion/relegation playoff at home on Monday, Wolfsburg - the 2009 Bundesliga champion - would drop a division for the first time since it was promoted to the top tier in 1997. Paderborn is bidding to return to the Bundesliga after it was relegated in 2020 after one season in the top flight.

The end-of-season playoff pits the team that finishes third from bottom in the Bundesliga against the third-place finisher in the second division to determine which will play in the top division the following season.

Towering Pele statue unveiled in Guadalajara before World Cup



A large statue of soccer great Pele was unveiled Thursday in the Mexican city of Guadalajara to commemorate his achievements with the Brazilian national team.

Pele, who died at age 82 in 2022, won one of his three World Cup titles in Mexico at the 1970 edition of the tournament.

"This monumental figure of this great player, who played here and scored a great goal, is a great gift to the people of Jalisco and to all visitors," Jalisco Gov. Pablo Lemus said. "Pele loved Guadalajara, and the Brazilian national team fell in love with it because the Mexican public gave them everything in 1970."

The 9.5-metre-tall (31-foot) statue is located in a public square called Plaza Brazil outside the Jalisco Stadium, which hosted matches in the 1970 and 1986 World Cups. For its 1970 title run, Brazil played its first-round, quarterfinal, and semifinal matches at the stadium before beating Italy in the final at Azteca Stadium in Mexico City.

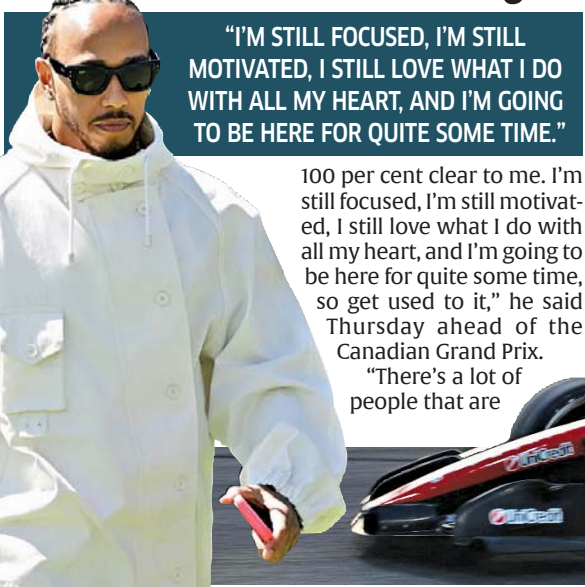
Lewis Hamilton says he's staying with F1

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Montreal

Lewis Hamilton has pushed back against what he calls people "trying to retire me" and insists he'll be staying in Formula 1 for "quite some time" to come.

The 41-year-old seven-time F1 champion appeared to confirm that his Ferrari contract covers 2027 as he was asked about next year after an up-and-down start to his second season with the Italian team.

"I'm still in contract, so everything's



"I'M STILL FOCUSED, I'M STILL MOTIVATED, I STILL LOVE WHAT I DO WITH ALL MY HEART, AND I'M GOING TO BE HERE FOR QUITE SOME TIME."

100 per cent clear to me. I'm still focused, I'm still motivated, I still love what I do with all my heart, and I'm going to be here for quite some time, so get used to it," he said Thursday ahead of the Canadian Grand Prix.

"There's a lot of people that are

trying to retire me, and that's not even on my thoughts. I'm already thinking of what will be next and planning for the next five years. But yeah, I still plan to be here for some time." Hamilton earned his first Grand Prix podium for Ferrari in China in March after a wait of over a year, but he's behind teammate Charles Leclerc in the standings and has been stuck on a

record 105 wins since his last victory with Mercedes in 2024. **Hamilton's tears for Arsenal:** Hamilton also acknowledged he was tearful this week after his boyhood soccer team Arsenal ended a 22-year wait for the English Premier League title. "I think, like for everyone, very emotional. I shed a tear to

be honest," he said. The last time Arsenal won the title, Hamilton was a 19-year-old aspiring racer competing in Formula 3. "We've had so many close moments and to finally get it was, wow." A lot of emotion came up for me, and as I'm sure for so many people. I'm just so happy and proud of the team," Hamilton added.

Barcelona meets Lyonnes in clash of dynasties

GRAHAM DUNBAR ■ Oslo

Dynasties of European soccer past and present meet in the Women's Champions League final on Saturday.

Barcelona against OL Lyonnes in Oslo will be the fourth time in eight seasons the modern powers have played for the European title, and the first since Lyon was rebranded by owner Michele Kang.

In the new Champions League format, they tied on points atop the 18-team standings in December.

Both teams also are unbeaten in domestic competitions this season, both chasing a quadruple of trophies.

"The two greatest teams probably of all time," said UEFA director of women's football Nadine Kessler, herself a three-time Champions League winner before Lyon started a run of five straight titles in 2015.

It is Barcelona's sixth straight final - and seventh in eight years - in an era shaped by their great attacking midfielders Aitana Bonmati and Alexia Putellas.

Lyon returns still with talismanic players Wendie Renard and Ada Hegerberg, respectively the captain and hat trick scorer when Barcelona was beaten 4-1 in the 2019 final.

There is an extra layer of



intrigue in the dugouts among teams that know each other so well.

Lyon coach Jonatan Giraldez won back-to-back Champions League titles at Barcelona when its current coach, Pere Romeu, was among his assistants.

Overcomes squad cutsBarcelona is back in the final one year after

being denied an expected three-peat by a 1-0 win for Arsenal.

The season started in some turmoil with squad cuts enforced as part of wider financial issues to help the club meet limits set by the men's La Liga.

On the field, it was domination again. The Spanish league title was retained with two rounds left and a record so far of played 28, won 27, lost 1. A 1-0 win for Real Sociedad in November is the only game Barcelona lost all season.

The Spanish cup and super cup trophies also were lifted, and Romeu's team has reached the Champions League final by topping the league phase standings then eliminating Real Madrid and Bayern Munich.

Barcelona is favored to win a fourth European title after 2021, 23 and '24, when it finally beat Lyon, 2-0. (AP)



Ronaldo ends Saudi trophy drought with two goals in Al-Nassr's win

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Riyadh

Cristiano Ronaldo has finally won a major trophy with Al-Nassr. The 41-year-old Portugal star scored twice in a 4-1 win over Damac to help Al-Nassr clinch the Saudi Pro League title Thursday. It's the team's first major trophy since Ronaldo joined more than three years ago.

Ronaldo lifted the trophy just two days after being named in Portugal's roster for the World Cup, which would mark a record sixth appearance at the tournament. The victory secured top spot for Al-Nassr, two points ahead of city rival Al-Hilal, which finished second despite completing the 34-



game season undefeated.

Ronaldo struck his 27th and 28th league goals of the season in the second half after Sadio Mane and Kingsley Coman scored on either side of half-time to put Al-Nassr in control.

Al-Nassr was leading 2-1 when Ronaldo restored his team's two-goal cushion just past the hour mark, curling a free kick from the left side through traffic and into the net.

Alexi Lalas says US players citing World Cup pressure are a 'bunch of whiners'

RONALD BLUM ■ New York

Alexi Lalas doesn't want to hear US players citing pressure ahead of playing in a World Cup at home and says Christian Pulisic, the top American, is "never going to be the leader."

"Cry me a river, OK, when it comes to the pressure. Bunch of whiners, that they're whining about the pressure," Lalas said Thursday at a Fox event to promote its World Cup coverage.

Lalas, 55, played for the US



when it hosted the 1994 World Cup and has been Fox's top soccer analyst since late 2014.

American players, hoping

to reach the quarterfinals for the first time since 2002, haven't complained about pressure but have said it exists. (AP)

Scheffler chasing at CJ Cup Byron Nelson, Koepka seeks first post-LIV win

SCHUYLER DIXON ■ McKinney (USA)

Scottie Scheffler won't be the wire-to-wire winner of his hometown CJ Cup Byron Nelson again this year.

For now, the world's top-ranked player is chasing a leaderboard that includes Brooks Koepka, the five-time major champion looking for his first victory since returning to the PGA Tour from LIV Golf.

Koepka shot an 8-under 63 on Thursday and trailed first-round leader Taylor Moore by one at the revamped TPC Craig Ranch, with Scheffler at 66 while playing with



Koepka and Si Woo Kim, one of seven players at 64.

"I felt like I was getting lapped out there for a little bit," said Scheffler, who led from the start of last year's Nelson and won by eight shots at 31 under while tying the tour's 72-hole scoring record at 253. "So I was fortunate to make a couple birdies late in the round and keep myself in the tournament."

Moore, whose only win in his first 128 tour starts came at the 2023 Valspar Championship, made a 14-foot birdie putt from the fringe on the par-5 ninth to finish the best

round of his tour career.

The Texas native and Oklahoma resident leads Koepka and Jesper Svensson, who had a chance to join Moore atop the leaderboard but missed a 9-footer on the ninth.

Kim — the highest-ranked player in the field behind Scheffler at No. 24 — had the only bogey in the threesome, on his 16th hole at the par-3 seventh.

One of several countrymen in the event sponsored by South Korean conglomerate CJ Group, Kim closed the gap on Koepka with a birdie at the ninth while Koepka settled for par. (AP)

US defender Chris Richards has ankle ligament damage ahead of World Cup



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ London

United States center back Chris Richards tore ligaments in his ankle, Crystal Palace manager Oliver Glasner said Thursday, three weeks before the start of the World Cup.

The 26-year-old Richards went down in the second half of Palace's 2-2 draw with Brentford on Sunday in the Premier League. He could return for the UEFA Conference League final next Wednesday against Rayo Vallecano in Leipzig.

"He tore, I think, two liga-

ments in his ankle," Glasner said Thursday after confirming that Richards would sit out Sunday's season finale against Arsenal. "It's now 50-50 for him, for us that he can play the (Conference League) final."

The injury will be a concern for US coach Mauricio Pochettino, who is days away from announcing his World Cup squad. "It's stable, but it's quite swollen, and now we have to deal with the swelling," Glasner said. "Of course, he needs to get back on the pitch to be available, and it will be really a race against time.

Mexico launches campaign to stop a homophobic chant

CARLOS RODRIGUEZ ■ Mexico City

Less than a month before the start of the 2026 World Cup, the Mexican Football Federation announced on Thursday a new advertising campaign that seeks to prevent its fans from using a chant considered homophobic during the tournament.

The chant, that has been an unwelcome feature at matches involving Mexico and its fervent fans for two decades, has resurfaced strongly in recent weeks, including the Liga MX play-offs matches held just last weekend. The name of the advertising campaign launched by the Mexican Federation is "The Wave Yes, The Chant No" and it features former Mexican national team players from the 1986 World Cup.

Mexican Wave dates to 1986: The creation of the Wave, the coordinated movement of fans in stadiums, is attributed to George "Krazy" Henderson, an American fan who began



orchestrating it at the Oakland Coliseum in 1981, but it became popular globally at the 1986 World Cup in Mexico and began to be called the "Mexican Wave".

"This campaign aims to raise awareness among fans about the importance of supporting the Mexican national team with the wave and not with discriminatory chants that FIFA sanctions," the federation said in a statement.

Mexico will be the first country to host the World

Cup three times, starting on June 11 when it faces South Africa in the opening match. The country was also the host nation in 1970 and 1986, but will share hosting duties this year with the United States and Canada.

"It was at a World Cup 40 years ago that The Wave was immortalized, a movement of unity that remains in stadiums today as one of the most significant and iconic legacies of international football."

This is a new attempt by Mexican soccer officials to end the chant that has earned them a dozen FIFA sanctions, as well as criticism from LGBT+ organizations, who claim that the federation does nothing to stop the practice in Mexican stadiums.

Appealing to CAS: Mexico currently has appeals against FIFA punishment over a 2024 match against the US pending before the Court of Arbitration for Sport. (AP)

USFF should contact Guardiola for becoming American coach

RONALD BLUM ■ New York

Former players Alexi Lalas and Stu Holden along with fellow Fox broadcasters Rebecca Lowe and Rob Stone all think the US Soccer Federation should contact Pep Guardiola about taking over as the American national team's coach after the World Cup.

"Pep would be a wonderful hire. He's a visionary. He's one of the best coaches that's ever coached in this game," Holden said Thursday at an event to promote Fox's World Cup coverage.

Guardiola is expected to leave Manchester City after Sunday's finale of his 10th season as manager.

Mauricio Pochettino, the former Tottenham manager who took over the U.S. team from Gregg Berhalter in late 2024, has a contract through the World Cup and has said he isn't sure whether he would be interested in a new US deal. Guardiola is likely to be highly sought.

"I don't know if he takes the call, but he might even be calling you," said Lalas, a star U.S. defender at the 1994 World Cup. "He's never coached internationally. He's also never coached a team that's not an elite team. ... He might not be the right guy, but you definitely have that conversation."

Lowe, a British-born, naturalized American who grew up in London and lives in California, has hosted NBC's Premier League coverage since 2013 and will be working for Fox for the first time next month.

"Having somebody like Pep would double or triple the fan base in my opinion in this



country because they're out there but they need to fall in love with the U.S. men's national team," she said. "And then on the field, he will improve the players. I know he won't get them very often, but when he gets them, he'll improve them. Imagine if you're Weston McKennie and Pep Guardiola is your manager? You are running through a brick wall for that man."

Guardiola, a 55-year-old Spaniard, won two Champions League titles with Barcelona and one with Manchester City along six Premier League championships and three in La Liga and also in the Bundesliga with Bayern Munich.

After coaching Barcelona from 2008-12, he moved to New York for a one-year sabbatical, then led Bayern Munich from 2013-16 before switching to Manchester.

"He's the kind of guy who would like that new challenge: taking over a national team, coming to a country that probably feels like his second or third home," Stone said. "So this is that next logical challenge." (AP)

PBKS eye dramatic revival for playoff spot

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lucknow

Punjab Kings will need something spectacular to arrest a disastrous slide and keep their fading playoff hopes alive when they take on already-eliminated Lucknow Super Giants, in their IPL clash, here on Saturday. Punjab's campaign has unravelled dramatically since their record 265-run chase against Delhi Capitals on April 25.

From remaining unbeaten till the midway stage and looking like genuine title contenders with six wins in seven matches, the last season's runners-up have crashed to six successive defeats, leaving their playoff hopes hanging by a thread.

Now placed fifth, Punjab not only need to beat LSG in their



final league game here on Saturday but also depend on Sunday's double headers (MI vs RR and KKR vs DC) to earn a place in the playoff. The Shreyas Iyer-led side would hope both Mumbai Indians and Kolkata Knight Riders lose their respective matches.



A Rajasthan Royals win over Mumbai would officially end Punjab's hopes, while a KKR victory over Delhi Capitals could bring net run rate into play. At present, PBKS hold a slight edge in NRR over KKR.

But before permutations come into the picture, Punjab first need to rediscover their form after a prolonged slump that has exposed flaws across departments.

Their aggressive top order of Priyansh Arya, Prabhsimran

Singh and Cooper Connolly has failed to provide the explosive starts that defined the first half of their season.

Priyansh has managed just one fifty in his last seven innings and was dismissed for a duck in the previous game, while Prabhsimran too has struggled for consistency with only one fifty in his last five innings.

Connolly has shown glimpses but has not converted starts into substantial scores. Having remained among the leaders in run-getters' tally, captain Iyer's returns too have dipped sharply during the losing streak, crossing fifty only once in the six defeats.

The middle order, which scripted the memorable chase against Delhi, has also lost momentum, while their bowling unit has leaked runs regularly at both ends of the innings.

Fielding has further hurt their campaign, with dropped catches proving costly in crucial moments.

LSG, meanwhile, have endured a forgettable season and are out of playoff contention after managing just two wins in their last 10 matches.

They suffered a seven-wicket defeat to Rajasthan Royals in Jaipur in their previous outing, a game dominated by teenage sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi. Yet, the home side would take confidence from their recent performances at the Ekana Stadium, where both they secured both their last two wins — against Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Chennai Super Kings.

SRH outclass RCB but fail to clinch top-two spot

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Hyderabad

Sunrisers Hyderabad maintained their now familiar hell-for-leather template, but even a thumping 55-run victory couldn't prevent Royal Challengers Bengaluru from topping the points table at the end of their IPL league stage engagement here on Friday.

Abhishek Sharma's bat-swing, Ishan Kishan's daredevilry and Heinrich Klaasen's brute muscularity took SRH to a meaty total of 255 for 4.

For RCB, the primary target was to score 166 to finish in top two and ensure two shots at qualifying for the IPL final and they did that with ease despite losing the contest by a big margin. They finished on 200 for 4.

RCB (NRR +0.783), thus, topped the group league phase with Gujarat Titans (NRR +0.695) and SRH (NRR +0.524) finishing second and third respectively despite all three teams getting 18 points apiece.

The chase was always out of question even as Venkatesh Iyer (44 off 19 balls) provided a solid start. Virat Kohli (15 off 11



balls) and Devdutt Padikkal (21 off 14 balls) didn't get too many.

Once RCB understood that they can't win the match, veterans Rajat Patidar (56 off 39 balls) and Krunal Pandya (41 not out off 31 balls) concentrated on the 'Magic Figure' of 166 with a 84-run stand.

Once Patidar played Pat Cummins over deep point

for a six, RCB ensured a top-two finish. He was out at the team score of 178, which was required to finish on top of the table.

Among SRH bowlers, Eshan Malinga (2/33 in 4 overs) was once again brilliant with his lengths, while Bihar youngster Sakib Hussain (1/31) also didn't let the batters get away during middle overs.

Batting with Kohli made a big difference in my growth: Padikkal



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bengaluru

Royal Challengers Bengaluru batter Devdutt Padikkal says opening alongside Virat Kohli in his debut IPL season helped him understand the art of constructing an innings, a lesson that continues to shape his approach in T20 cricket.

Padikkal, who burst onto the scene with Royal Challengers Bengaluru in the 2020 IPL, said watching Kohli operate from close quarters gave him invaluable insight early in his career.

"When I made my IPL debut with RCB in the 2020 season, I felt ready. I had a solid run of scores in domestic cricket behind me," Padikkal said during an interaction on JioStar.

"And batting with Virat Kohli, one of the greatest in the game, was a huge help. At that age, watching him build an innings gave me so much clarity and understanding of how to construct a knock. That made a big difference in my growth," he added.

The Karnataka batter said his subsequent stints with Rajasthan Royals and Lucknow Super Giants, where he batted in multiple positions, broadened his understanding of the game.

"Moving from being a dedicated opener to batting in different positions lower down the order was challenging, especially at a young age. But those experiences with Rajasthan Royals and Lucknow Super Giants shaped me into the player I am today," he said.

GT thriving by not dwelling on imperfections: Rashid

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ahmedabad

Aware of the scrutiny around Gujarat Titans' middle order, star spinner Rashid Khan said the side has succeeded this season by not dwelling on imperfections but trusting players to deliver in different situations, and adapting quickly to conditions.

GT registered a massive 89-run win over Chennai Super Kings in their last league match on Thursday to take the top two positions in the points table.

"I think every team has those little bit areas to improve and have some areas very strong. You can't be a complete 100 per cent perfect team. Doesn't matter how good a player you will have... throughout the tournament there has been lots of discussion about our middle order and things like that but I feel everyone is stepping up," he said.

"Everyone is taking the responsibility and I feel like



that's so important. If you keep thinking about those 10 per cent or 15 per cent you are not accurate, it's going to affect the rest of 70-75 or 80 per cent. "For us the thing is that we just keep the thing simple. Whoever the opposition is,

how are we going to be more impactful whoever gets the opportunity in the middle. Either you bat, bowl or field. So don't much think about where we weak, where we strong. Think about what is in front of me and how I can do better for the team."

Rashid heaped praise on the bowlers for their consistent effort this season.

"The wicket didn't change. I think the bowling attack we have, especially the fast bowling unit we have, we have done a really great job throughout the tournament," Rashid said.

"And I feel like on this wicket, if you hit the right area consistently with a good pace, there is something for the bowler. While putting score on the board, you just don't go with the flow, you just see the condition first and then you try to play accordingly."

CSK's Ruturaj Gaikwad fined for slow over-rate vs GT

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ahmedabad

Chennai Super Kings captain Ruturaj Gaikwad has been fined after his team maintained a slow over-rate during their IPL match against Gujarat Titans.

Gujarat Titans sealed a top-two finish in the IPL playoffs with a commanding 89-run victory over Chennai Super Kings in their final league match here on Thursday.

The defeat also ended the five-time champions' slim hopes of qualifying for the last four.

"As this was his team's second offence (first offence in Match 18) of the season under Article 2.22 of the IPL's Code of Conduct, which pertains to minimum over-rate



offences, Gaikwad was fined INR 24 lakhs," said an IPL media advisory issued on Friday.

The remaining members of the Playing XI, including the Impact Player, have been fined either ₹6 lakh or 25 per cent of their respective match fees, whichever is lower.

Babar, Shahdab, Naseem returns to Pakistan squad

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lahore

Senior batter Babar Azam, all-rounder Shahdab Khan and pacer Naseem Shah on Friday returned to Pakistan's ODI squad for the upcoming three-match series against Australia at home.

The Pakistani selectors have named a 16-member squad, which includes two wicket-keepers for the home series which begins on May 30 in Rawalpindi, with the remaining two games to be played in Lahore on June 2 and 4. Left-arm fast bowler Shaheen Shah Afridi will continue to lead the ODI squad. The selectors have dropped



six players from the 15-member squad that went to Bangladesh in March and lost the series 1-2.

Mohammad Rizwan, Faheem Ashraf, Faisal Akram, Saad Masood, Mohammad Wasim Junior and Hussain Talat have been dropped from the squad that went to Bangladesh while Babar, Shahdab and Naseem, who were not in that team have

been recalled. Openers Fakhar Zaman and Saim Ayub were unavailable for selection as they are nursing injuries.

The selectors have also picked up two uncapped players in the revamped side,

mystery spin, or Mitchell Starc's left-arm thunderbolts — all for daily allowances that are modest by IPL standards but invaluable as a career. Their only dream is wearing a franchise jersey instead of carrying drinks and spare balls.

IPL franchises usually keep around three to five specialist net bowlers with them, apart from the local bowlers arranged by host state associations and clubs at different venues. (PTI)



Sweetie Kujur to lead India at U-18 women's Asia Cup



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Sweetie Kujur was on Friday named captain of the 18-member Indian women's U-18 squad for the Asia Cup hockey tournament to be held in Kakamigahara, Japan from May 29-June 6.

The squad features a five-member forward line led by Kujur, alongside Nouseen Naz, Priyanka Minz, Sandeepa Kumari and Nancy Saroha.

The midfield will comprise Shruti Kumari, Diya, Sneha Davde, Rashmeen Kaur, Nammi Geetashree and Pushpa Manjhi.

Pakistan hockey players complain about pending dues, daily allowance ahead of WC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Karachi

Pakistani hockey players' financial woes continued as they are yet to receive pending dues from the national federation (PHF) and their daily training camp allowance has also been reduced ahead of the FIH World Cup to be held in the Netherlands and Belgium in August this year.

The Pakistan Hockey Federation's (PHF) interim set-up announced that players and officials of the national team will now receive a daily allowance of USD 110 on foreign tours.

But the players have complained that their training camp allowance has been reduced from USD 11 (3000 rupees) to USD 3.5 (1000 rupees).

According to a reliable source close



to the PHF, the senior players had asked the PHF to confirm about how much allowance they would get for the training camp duration.

Pakistan on Thursday named their

20-member squad for next month's FIH Pro League matches in Belgium and England but didn't name the captain, a move that didn't go down well with the players.